

MUGEN SWING

Syncope, Debt, and the Dream-Phantasm in Cowboy Bebop

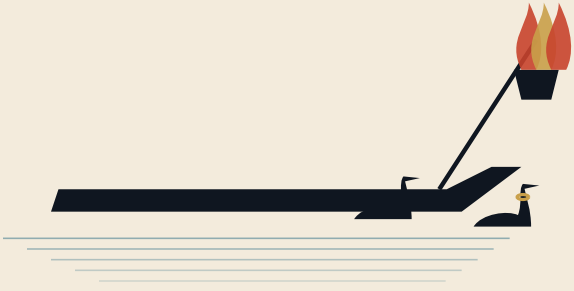
TOWARD A SYNCOPIC ONTOLOGY OF THE UNPAID HUNTER

おもしろうて
やがて悲しき
鵜舟かな

omoshirōte
yagate kanashiki
ubune kana

Delightful, and then, soon enough, sorrowful:
the cormorant boats.

MATSUO BASHŌ · GIFU · 1688 · AUTHOR'S TRANSLATION



SET LIST

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that *Cowboy Bebop* (dir. Shinichirō Watanabe; series composition and principal screenplay by Keiko Nobumoto; Sunrise, 1998–99), together with its cinematic supplement *Cowboy Bebop: Knockin' on Heaven's Door* (2001), is not a pastiche of twentieth-century genres but a rigorous, formally self-aware philosophy of existence after catastrophe, one articulated less through propositions than through rhythm. Against readings that would assimilate the series to Fredric Jameson's "blank parody" or to Azuma Hiroki's database consumption, it contends that the series' quotations operate as improvisational *signifyin(g)*, in Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s sense, over a fixed harmonic ground: the Gate Accident of 2022, which shattered the Moon and scattered humanity across the solar system. From that ground the series derives what this study names a **syncopic ontology**: a model of the subject as constituted by an elided beat (a missing past, organ, parent or memory) and condemned to live on the off-beat of a history whose downbeat has already fallen.

The argument proceeds in four movements. **Part One** reconstructs the formal and historical conditions of the series: the jazz grammar of the "session" (head, solos, return; the cutting contest; the blues as repetition with difference), and the post-catastrophic, post-bubble geography of a solar frontier whose tolled gates and privatised bounties allegorise both Japan's "lost decade" and the neoliberal outsourcing of justice. **Part Two** reads the principal figures as four incompatible temporalities. Spike Spiegel appears as revenant and mirror, read through Kierkegaard's *Øieblik* and Heidegger's *Augenblick*, Camus's absurd, Kuki Shūzō's *iki* and Bruce Lee's Jeet Kune Do. Jet Black appears as the gardener of a ruined law, through Watsuji Tetsurō's *aidagara*, the ethics of care and Ozu Yasujirō's elegiac paternity. Faye Valentine appears as Urashima's daughter, through Bergson, Benjamin, Freudian *Nachträglichkeit* and the inverted fairy tale. Edward and Ein appear as the ludic and animal remainder, through Haraway, Huizinga, Schiller and Derrida. A seventh chapter reads Vicious, Julia and the Red Dragon through the iconography of *ukai* cormorant fishing and Bashō's cormorant-boat haiku, René Girard's mimetic rivalry, and the *giri–ninjō* dialectic of Chikamatsu Monzaemon and the *ninkyō* yakuza film. **Part Three** identifies three false exits from syncope (sovereign nihilism, digital transcendence and apocalyptic oblivion) and situates the series among its kin: Marker's *La Jetée*, Lem's and Tarkovsky's *Solaris*, Gibson's *Neuromancer*, Bester's *The Stars My Destination*, Le Guin's *The Dispossessed*, Jarmusch's *Dead Man*, the Orphic and Izanagi descents, the Urashima cycle, Wagner's *Der fliegende Holländer*, Zhuangzi's butterfly and Sano Yōko's *The Cat That Lived a Million Times*.

Part Four assembles these findings into an original synthesis, here called **Mugen Swing**. It advances four linked theses. First, the series is structurally homologous with Zeami's *mugen nō*,

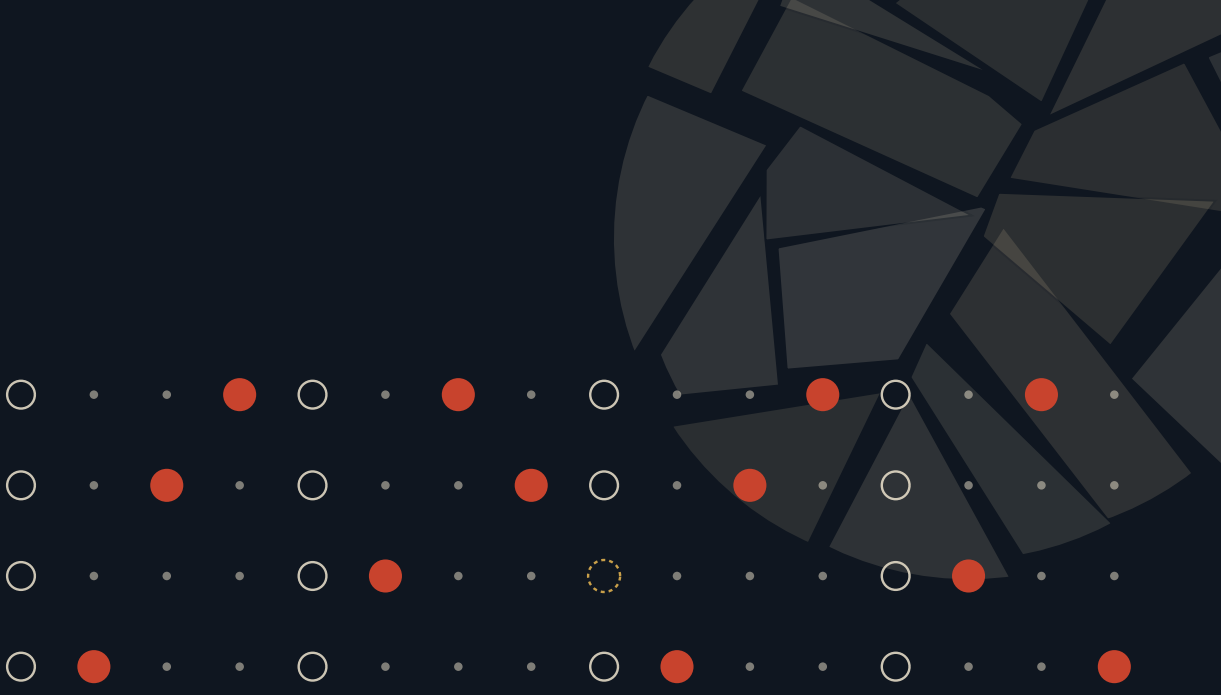
the “dream-phantasm” drama in which a ghost bound by attachment re-enacts its death before a wandering witness and then vanishes: the comic sessions function as *kyōgen* interludes, the *Jupiter Jazz* diptych as the *nakairi* (the ghost’s mid-play exit) with Gren as its narrating *ai-kyōgen*, and the final session as the *nochiba* in which the ghost appears in its true form. Second, the bounty hunters inhabit an **ubune economy**: like the ringed cormorants of Nagara River fishing, they catch what they cannot swallow, so that hunger, debt and the unpaid “head” become the material form of their metaphysical suspension. Third, Spike’s ending enacts a **heterodox release**, in which liberation from repetition is achieved not by Buddhist non-attachment but by the consummation of attachment in grief. Fourth, the crew’s provisional community models an **ethics of comping** (accompaniment without fusion) that survives the dissolution of the band. The dissertation concludes that *Cowboy Bebop* offers a philosophy of afterlife for the living: an account of how to inhabit the interval (*ma*) between a catastrophe that has already happened and a death that has not yet arrived, and of how to make that interval not a waiting room but a session.

CITATION, ROMANIZATION AND TRANSLATION

A NOTE ON TEXTS

The primary corpus comprises the twenty-six televised sessions of *Cowboy Bebop* (Sunrise; partial broadcast TV Tokyo, April–June 1998; complete broadcast WOWOW, October 1998–April 1999) and the feature *Cowboy Bebop: Tengoku no tobira* (*Knockin' on Heaven's Door*, 2001). The recap special shown during the partial TV Tokyo run, "Mish-Mash Blues," falls outside the corpus. Episodes are cited as "Session *n*" with their English titles; the film is abbreviated *KOHD*. Authorship is treated as distributed: Watanabe directed; Nobumoto composed the series and wrote its spine, with screenplays also by Michiko Yokote, Sadayuki Murai, Akihiko Inari, Dai Satō and Ryōta Yamaguchi; Toshihiro Kawamoto designed the characters, Kimitoshi Yamane the machines, and Yoko Kanno composed the score with the studio ensemble The Seatbelts; the original creator is credited to the Sunrise collective pseudonym Hajime Yatate. When this study writes "the series argues," it attributes an argument to the work's formal intelligence, not to a single intending mind. Production details (the sponsorship history, the order in which music and story were developed, the director's stated intentions) are drawn from published interviews and commentaries as compiled in the Wikipedia article on the series, consulted on 26 October 2026, and are listed in the bibliography under their original sources.

Japanese names appear surname-first except where a creator is internationally known in Western order (Shinichirō Watanabe, Keiko Nobumoto, Yoko Kanno), and Japanese terms follow modified Hepburn romanization. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed, and song lyrics are never reproduced; musical works are discussed by title, form and function. Translations of pre-modern Japanese, Chinese, Danish and German sources are the author's own unless a published translation is named. Classical texts are cited by conventional divisions (section, chapter, poem number) rather than by the pagination of particular editions. Dates in parentheses give first publication or release; where a work circulated before publication, the composition date is noted.



INTRODUCTION · COUNT-IN

THE WEAK BEAT OF THE FUTURE

> *They are a band without a gig, playing sessions in the ruins of a future that already looks like the past.*

I.1 A SERIES THAT NAMES ITSELF A GENRE
I.2 THE THESIS
I.3 METHOD
I.4 STATE OF THE FIELD
I.5 ARCHITECTURE OF THE ARGUMENT

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I.1 A SERIES THAT NAMES ITSELF A GENRE

Cowboy Bebop opens with a wager on its own classification. Its original broadcasts were punctuated, before and after the commercial breaks, by a tagline announcing that the work would become a new genre unto itself, a genre bearing the oxymoron of its name. Watanabe later called the phrase an exaggeration; it deserves to be taken at its word nonetheless, because the oxymoron is exact. The cowboy belongs to the iconography of the frontier, of horizontal expansion, of territory taken and law founded at gunpoint; bebop belongs to the iconography of the night club, of vertical harmonic density, of time subdivided and displaced by players who had inherited a form and resolved to make it unrecognisable from within. The cowboy is a figure of space; bebop is a discipline of time. To join them is to propose that a culture which has exhausted its spaces (whose frontier has closed, in Frederick Jackson Turner's famous diagnosis of 1893) might survive by improvising in time. That proposition is the subject of this dissertation.

The proposition is staged under conditions of explicit catastrophe. In the series' backstory, an accident in an experimental hyperspace gate in 2022 fractured the Moon; its debris has rained on Earth ever since, driving most of humanity underground or outward to Mars, Venus, the Jovian moons and the asteroid belt. By 2071, the narrative present, the solar system is a diaspora without a homeland. Police authority is thin and corrupt, and the old institution of the bounty has been revived to supplement it. The protagonists are bounty hunters who are almost never paid. Their kitchen produces a dish of bell peppers and beef that, for want of money, contains no beef. They are a band without a gig, playing sessions in the ruins of a future that already looks like the past.

I.2 THE THESIS

This study argues that the series' apparently eclectic surface (its collisions of Western, noir, kung fu, yakuza film, space opera, slapstick and art cinema, and its score's migrations among bebop, blues, country, funk, chant and opera) is the visible form of a coherent ontology. That ontology is syncopic. In music, syncopation displaces accent from the strong to the weak beat; in grammar, syncope elides a sound from within a word; in medicine, syncope is the swoon, the brief absence of the subject from itself; in the mystical tradition reconstructed by Catherine Clément (*La Syncope: philosophie du ravissement*, 1990), it is rapture, the ecstatic suspension in which time is cut. Every principal figure of the series lives in one or more of these registers. Each is constituted by an elision (Spike's eye and faked death, Jet's arm, Faye's erased decades and memory, Edward's absent father). Each inhabits a displaced accent, living on the weak beat of a history whose strong beat, the Gate Accident, has already fallen. Each courts the swoon: Spike sleeps through whole afternoons, falls through a cathedral window, and ends, in the most famous gesture of the medium, by collapsing on a staircase after a whispered *bang*.

The dissertation's original contribution is to show that this syncopic ontology is not merely thematic but architectural, and that it binds together traditions that criticism has kept apart. The series' jazz grammar (head, solos, return) and its Japanese dramaturgy (the ghost play of Zeami, with its interval of non-action and its interludes of comedy) turn out to be two notations for one structure. Its political economy (the uncollected bounty, the perpetual debt) and its metaphysics (the dream from which Spike cannot wake) turn out to be two descriptions of one suspension. Its existentialist inheritance (Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Camus) and its Buddhist inheritance (impermanence, the dream-like character of conditioned things) turn out not to compete but to correct one another, producing an ending that neither tradition alone could authorise.

I.3 METHOD

The method is comparative hermeneutics in the strong sense: the construction of what Walter Benjamin and, after him, Theodor Adorno called a *constellation*, in which heterogeneous elements are arranged so that their configuration discloses a truth none of them contains alone. The series invites such a procedure because it is itself built constellationally. Its episode titles cite the Rolling Stones, Queen, Led Zeppelin, Aerosmith, KISS, Herbie Hancock, Bill Evans and Godard; its images cite John Woo, Bruce Lee, Sergio Leone, Ridley Scott and the Toei yakuza cycle; its plots cite *Alien*, blaxploitation, the space-shuttle programme and the Unabomber. To read it well is to read it as it reads.

Three methodological commitments follow. The first concerns intention. Claims about influence are made only where the series' own surface (a title, a name, an image, a narrated fable) makes the debt legible. Claims about homology, such as the correspondence with *mugen nō*, are offered as interpretive constructions whose warrant is explanatory power, not authorial confirmation. The second concerns cultural translation. The series is a Japanese work that speaks a deliberately mixed idiom, and it would be an error both to Orientalise it (reading every pause as Zen) and to Occidentalise it (reading every gunfight as Leone). The constellation must keep both fields visible at once. The third concerns form. Animation is not illustrated literature, and the arguments here attend to timing, cutting, layout, sound and silence, following Thomas Lamarre's insistence that anime thinks through its technical apparatus (*The Anime Machine*, 2009).

I.4 STATE OF THE FIELD

Anglophone anime studies has treated the series more as an emblem than as an object. Susan Napier's influential typology of anime's apocalyptic, festival and elegiac modes (*Anime from Akira to Princess Mononoke*, 2001; revised 2005) provides the most useful general frame: *Cowboy Bebop* is the rare text that braids all three, staging festival comedy and elegiac grief on an apocalyptic ground. Lamarre's distinction between the ballistic "cinematism" of depth and the lateral "animetism" of sliding planes helps describe the series' alternation between kinetic combat and stilled contemplation. Azuma Hiroki's account of postmodern otaku consumption as the browsing of a database of affective elements (*Dōbutsuka suru posutomodan*, 2001; English 2009) offers a powerful counter-model that this study contests: the series' citations do not float free in a database but are bound to loss. Iwabuchi Kōichi's concept of *mukokuseki*, the "statelessness" or cultural odourlessness that eased anime's global circulation (*Recentering Globalization*, 2002), describes the series' hybrid surface but not its melancholy, which is precisely the odour of a lost place. Marc Steinberg (*Anime's Media Mix*, 2012) and Ian Condry (*The Soul of Anime*, 2013) supply the industrial context of late-1990s production, in which the series' original toy-sponsor logic was displaced by a video-market model that licensed its adult tonality.

The two most sustained studies of the series itself sit at its edges. Rose Bridges's *Yoko Kanno's Cowboy Bebop Soundtrack* (2017) treats the score as a work in its own right, and Michelle Onley Pirkle's essay on the series' passage to the cinema (2011) describes its handling of genre as free play, remixing and adaptation of familiar images and sounds rather than the invention of new ones; the account of the contrafact in Chapter 1 may be read as an attempt to give that remixing a grammar. Brian Camp and Julie Davis (*Anime Classics Zettai!*, 2007) note the crew's resemblance to the gang of *Lupin III*, whose first television series Watanabe has named as his principal model, and judge the resemblance superficial beside the darker pasts and more complex inner lives the series gives its characters. Both observations point the same way: the series borrows its forms in order to load them with a history they did not carry.

Robert Baigent (2004) located the series' appeal in a broader tendency of anime to emulate Western fiction. This study accepts the observation and rejects its implication: emulation describes the surface, signifyin(g) the operation. Jonathan Clements's *Anime: A History* (2013) supplies the industrial frame of sponsors, studios and broadcasters within which Sunrise's late-1990s wager on an adult series without toys should be measured.

On the musical side, E. Taylor Atkins's *Blue Nippon* (2001) reconstructs the long Japanese negotiation with jazz authenticity, from interwar dance halls to post-war *jazz kissa*, and so supplies the historical depth behind Kanno's pastiche-that-is-not-pastiche. On the philosophical side, there is a large popular literature that pairs the series with existentialism, typically by aligning Spike with Camus's absurd hero and Vicious with nihilism. These alignments are not wrong, but they are incomplete in two respects. They neglect the Japanese philosophical tradition (Kuki Shūzō, Watsuji Tetsurō, Nishitani Keiji, Zeami, Dōgen) which offers more precise instruments.

And they neglect form, treating the series as a set of characters holding positions rather than as a temporal object whose rhythms are themselves arguments.
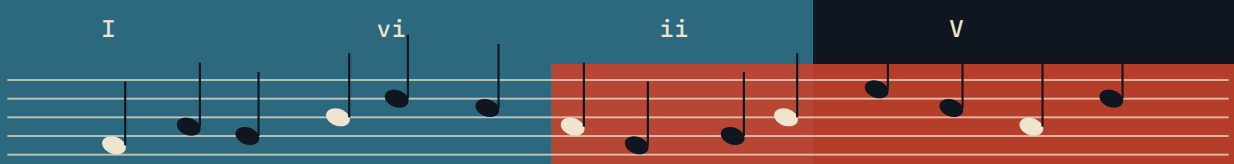
I.5 ARCHITECTURE OF THE ARGUMENT

Part One establishes conditions. Chapter 1 reconstructs the jazz grammar of the series: the session as unit, the head–solo–head structure, the cutting contest, and the blues as repetition with difference. It answers Adorno's and Jameson's suspicions about jazz and pastiche respectively. Chapter 2 maps the post-catastrophic solar system as a closed frontier, a privatised legal order and an allegory of Japan after 1991 and 1995.

Part Two reads the figures as temporalities. Chapter 3 treats Spike as a revenant whose two eyes see two times; Chapter 4 treats Jet as an ethical subject of care in a lawless order; Chapter 5 treats Faye as an anachronic subject cheated of her decades and indebted for her own resurrection; Chapter 6 treats Edward and Ein as the play and animality the household cannot keep; Chapter 7 treats Vicious, Julia and the Red Dragon as the gravitational system of the past.

Part Three tests the account against its alternatives. Chapter 8 examines three false exits from syncope that the series stages and refuses. Chapter 9 builds the comparative constellation across speculative, mythological and philosophical fiction.

Part Four, Chapter 10, assembles the synthesis, *Mugen Swing*, and the Conclusion returns to the final gesture, the word *bang*, to ask what it means to carry the weight the series assigns its audience in its last frame.



PART ONE · CONDITIONS

CHAPTER 1

THE GRAMMAR OF THE SESSION

Bebop, Blues and the Contrafact

> *Blank parody has forgotten history; blue parody remembers it too well.*

1

1.1 BEBOP AS A MODERNISM OF TIME
1.2 THE CONTRAFACT AS THE SERIES' COMPOSITIONAL PRINCIPLE
1.3 HEAD, SOLOS, HEAD: THE SESSION AS TEMPORAL FORM
1.4 THE CUTTING CONTEST
1.5 THE BLUES AS REPETITION WITH DIFFERENCE
1.6 THE SCORE AS NARRATOR
1.7 ANSWERING ADORNO
1.8 THE SESSIONS AND THEIR CHANGES
1.9 WHOSE BLUES? BORROWING, AUTHENTICITY AND THE HISTORY THE MUSIC CARRIES

THE SERIES' DEEPEST FORMAL decision is lexical: its episodes are called *sessions*. The word imports a whole social and technical grammar, and this chapter argues that the grammar governs the series at every scale, from the cut to the arc. Its central claim is that *Cowboy Bebop* is built on the logic of the bebop **contrafact**: a new melody written over the borrowed harmonic changes of an existing song. Genre is the borrowed changes; each session is a new head.

1.1 BEBOP AS A MODERNISM OF TIME

Bebop crystallised in the early 1940s in after-hours sessions at Minton's Playhouse and Monroe's Uptown House in Harlem, where Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, Thelonious Monk, Kenny Clarke and their peers transformed the dance-band idiom of swing into a music for listening. Its innovations were temporal before they were harmonic. Clarke moved the timekeeping pulse from the bass drum to the ride cymbal and freed the bass drum for irregular accents, the so-called "bombs" dropped on unexpected beats. Soloists phrased across bar lines, began lines on off-beats, and displaced accents so persistently that the underlying metre became a ghost the listener had to supply. Harmonically, the idiom elaborated the flattened fifth, the tritone substitution and dense passing chords, so that familiar progressions became unfamiliar terrain.

The historical point matters for interpretation. Bebop was not a style chosen from a menu but a strategy by Black American musicians to reclaim a commodified form, to make it difficult, fast, private and self-authorising. Amiri Baraka (then LeRoi Jones) read it in *Blues People* (1963) as a refusal of the role of entertainer assigned by a segregated culture industry. When a Japanese studio names a science-fiction series after this music, it inherits not a sound but a stance: the stance of practitioners who live inside a form they did not choose and make freedom out of the way they phrase it.

1.2 THE CONTRAFACT AS THE SERIES' COMPOSITIONAL PRINCIPLE

The characteristic bebop compositional act was the contrafact. Parker's "Donna Lee" rides the changes of "(Back Home Again in) Indiana"; "Ornithology" rides "How High the Moon"; Tadd Dameron's "Hot House" rides "What Is This Thing Called Love?"; and dozens of heads ride the "rhythm changes" of Gershwin's "I Got Rhythm." The practice was at once economic (a new melody evaded copyright on the old song), technical (familiar changes freed attention for improvisation), and philosophical: it affirmed that a structure can be inherited without being obeyed.

Cowboy Bebop composes this way. Session 11, "Toys in the Attic," keeps the changes of *Alien* (1979) intact (the enclosed vessel, the crew picked off one by one, the creature in the ductwork, the final ejection into space) and writes a new head in which the monster is a mould grown from forgotten food in the refrigerator. Session 17, "Mushroom Samba," keeps the changes of blaxploitation and the hallucinatory road movie and writes a head about a hungry child and her dog. Session 22, "Cowboy Funk," keeps the changes of the Western showdown and writes a head

about the impossibility of being a cowboy in a world where the cowboy survives only as costume. The great arc of the Red Dragon keeps the changes of the Hong Kong heroic-bloodshed film and the Japanese *ninkyō* yakuza picture and writes a head about a man who has already died once.

The contrafact clarifies what is wrong with treating the series as pastiche. Fredric Jameson defined pastiche as "blank parody," an imitation of dead styles without parody's satirical motive, symptomatic of a culture that has lost its sense of history (*Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*, 1991). Bebop's contrafacts were never blank: they were acts of appropriation with a stake. *Cowboy Bebop*'s are not blank either. This study proposes the term **blue parody** for citation coloured by loss: imitation that knows the original is gone and grieves while it plays. Blank parody has forgotten history; blue parody remembers it too well.

1.3 HEAD, SOLOS, HEAD: THE SESSION AS TEMPORAL FORM

The standard performance practice of small-group bebop is the head arrangement: the ensemble states the theme (the head), the players take turns improvising choruses over the changes, the soloists may "trade fours" (alternate four-bar phrases) toward the end, and the ensemble restates the head to close. This structure organises the series at two scales.

At the scale of the episode, a session typically states a head (a bounty, a target, a premise), lets its characters solo (each pursues the target by a different route, usually failing), and returns to the head in an altered key: the bounty is lost, the money gone, the dinner beefless again. At the scale of the series, the Red Dragon arc functions as the head. It is stated in Session 5 ("Ballad of Fallen Angels"), developed at the midpoint in Sessions 12 and 13 ("Jupiter Jazz"), and restated in Sessions 25 and 26 ("The Real Folk Blues"). Everything else is choruses over the changes. The production record supports the reading: Watanabe has said that he conceived the ending early and designed each episode involving Spike and Vicious to foreshadow the final confrontation, keeping it against staff who worried that it would make a continuation difficult. The arrangement explains a structural feature that conventional serial criticism finds puzzling: the series' mythology occupies only five of twenty-six sessions yet determines the meaning of all of them, as a head determines the meaning of the solos it frames without appearing in them.

The arrangement also contains a pun the series exploits without announcing it. In jazz the *head* is the theme; in bounty hunting the *head* is the quarry, the person on whose head a price is set. The bounty hunter's work is to bring in heads; the jazz player's work is to state and leave the head. *Cowboy Bebop* is the story of hunters who almost never bring in a head and of a protagonist whose own head is the price the past has set for him. Its final session states the head one last time and ends.

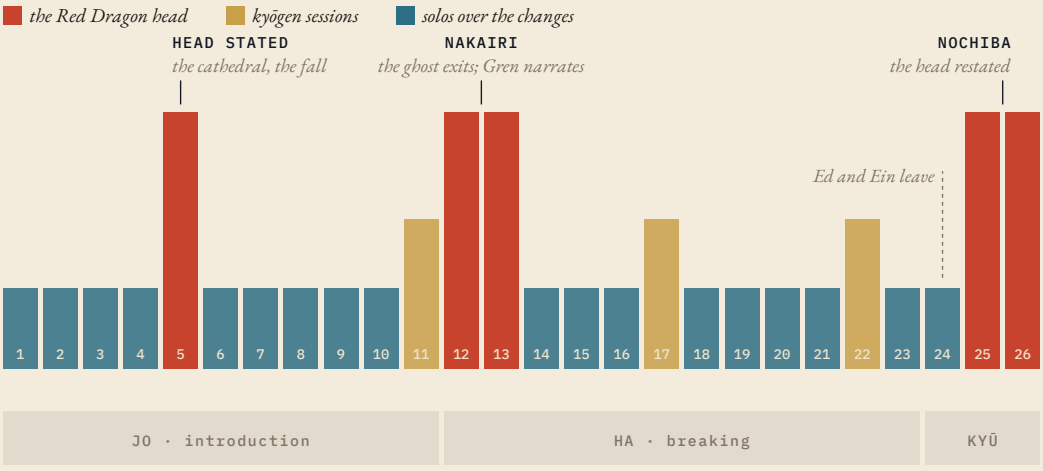


FIG. 1 *The arc as a head arrangement. Each bar is a session: red, the Red Dragon head (stated in 5, developed in 12–13, restated in 25–26); gold, the comic sessions read in Chapter 10 as* kyōgen*; teal, the solos. The bands below give one reading of* jo-ha-kyū.

1.4 THE CUTTING CONTEST

The jam session was also a site of combat. At Minton's, the "cutting contest" tested newcomers by calling tunes at punishing tempos in difficult keys. Players "cut" one another, and the session was a hierarchy enacted in time. The series translates the cutting contest into its duels. Spike's fights are not exchanges of force but contests of timing, in which victory goes to whoever enters the other's phrase at the unexpected beat. His style (derived, as Chapter 3 shows, from Bruce Lee's Jeet Kune Do, "the way of the intercepting fist") is interception: he strikes into the interval of the opponent's attack. The confrontations with Vicious are cutting contests in the strict sense, duels between players of the same school, trained in the same band, each trying to cut the other. Their last exchange ends in a simultaneity that no cutting contest admits: both players are cut.

1.5 THE BLUES AS REPETITION WITH DIFFERENCE

If bebop gives the series its tempo, the blues gives it its harmonic floor. The two final sessions take their title from the Chess Records LP series *The Real Folk Blues* (1965–66), which repackaged electric Chicago blues by Muddy Waters, Howlin' Wolf, John Lee Hooker and Sonny Boy Williamson for a folk-revival audience; the ending theme for most of the run bears the same title. The blues form is the paradigm of repetition with difference: the twelve-bar progression recurs, chorus after chorus, while what is sung and played over it never quite repeats.

Two theorists of African American aesthetics clarify what is at stake. Albert Murray's *Stomping the Blues* (1976) distinguished "the blues as such" (the condition of depression, bad luck and

low spirits) from blues *music*, which he read as a ritual of resilience that confronts the condition by naming it in rhythm and so holding it at bay. The Bebop crew are perpetually in the blues as such, broke, hungry and haunted; the series' sessions are blues music, the ritual by which they stomp it. Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) theorised African American vernacular art as *signifyin(g)*, repetition and revision that names its sources by transforming them. Signifyin(g) is the rhetorical principle of the contrafact, and it is the series' rhetorical principle too: each citation repeats in order to differ.

Gilles Deleuze, approaching repetition from another tradition, argued in *Différence et répétition* (1968) that genuine repetition is never the return of the same but the production of difference through return, and that habit, memory and death name three syntheses of time. Read alongside Murray and Gates, Deleuze helps explain why the series' recurrences (the beefless dinner, the uncollected bounty, the returning past) are not monotonous. They are choruses: each time the same changes come round, something new is played over them, until the final chorus, in which what is played is death.

1.6 THE SCORE AS NARRATOR

Yoko Kanno's score for the series is the most celebrated in television animation, and its importance is structural rather than decorative. By the production team's own account, the music was among the first elements developed, before the characters and story were final, and Watanabe has described his collaboration with Kanno as a game of catch in which her pieces prompted scenes and the scenes prompted further pieces, some of them never commissioned. The series was, in this literal sense, improvised around its score. Kanno's polystylism (big-band bebop in the opening theme "Tank!", Chicago blues, harmonica-driven country, funk, chant-like choral writing, operatic lament, singer-songwriter ballads) does not illustrate genres but supplies the changes over which each session improvises. The music frequently carries the narrative's emotional argument against its surface: in Session 5 the choral piece "Green Bird" turns a gunfight in a ruined church into a requiem, and in Session 13 the slow, ascending "Space Lion" turns the launch of a dead man's body toward Titan into an ascension.

The opening credits extend the analogy into design. Their flat silhouettes, hard colour fields and kinetic typography evoke the album covers Reid Miles designed for Blue Note Records between 1956 and 1967, and the title sequences Saul Bass made for Otto Preminger, above all the cut-paper body of *Anatomy of a Murder* (1959), scored by Duke Ellington. The credits declare at the threshold that what follows will be visual music: rhythm articulated in cuts and colour rather than in notes.

1.7 ANSWERING ADORNO

No account of the series' jazz grammar can avoid Theodor Adorno, whose essays "Über Jazz" (1936) and "Perennial Fashion—Jazz" (1953) remain the most rigorous hostile theory of the music. Adorno heard in jazz the pseudo-individualisation of a standardised commodity, and he heard in syncopation something more specific: the symbolic stumble of a weak ego that falls out of step with the collective only to be reabsorbed by it. The syncopated subject, for Adorno, rehearses rebellion as a gesture of impotence; the beat always wins.

The series accepts the first half of the analysis and refutes the second. Its protagonists are indeed weak, eccentric subjects who fall out of step with every collective (syndicate, police, family). But the series refuses reabsorption. Spike's final stumble on the staircase is not recuperated by any beat; the band breaks up; the session ends. Where Adorno saw syncopation as rebellion domesticated in advance, *Cowboy Bebop* stages syncope as an irreversible cut. Its answer to Adorno is not that jazz is free but that its unfreedom can be played to the end, and that playing it to the end is a form of freedom Adorno's dialectic has no place for.

1.8 THE SESSIONS AND THEIR CHANGES

The table sets out the twenty-six sessions with the principal source each title signifies upon and the head each writes over it. Where a title names a form rather than a work, the form is given.

SESSION	TITLE	CHANGES BORROWED (TITLE SOURCE)	HEAD WRITTEN OVER THEM
1	ASTEROID BLUES	The blues form	Lovers fleeing on a drug that alters time; the first failed escape
2	STRAY DOG STRUT	Stray Cats, "Stray Cat Strut" (1981)	A stolen data dog joins the ship; the hunter's animal
3	HONKY TONK WOMEN	Rolling Stones (1969)	Faye arrives through a casino; luck as debt
4	GATEWAY SHUFFLE	The shuffle rhythm	Eco-terror at a hyperspace gate; infrastructure as politics
5	BALLAD OF FALLEN ANGELS	The jazz ballad	Mao's murder, the cathedral, Spike's fall; the head first stated
6	SYMPATHY FOR THE DEVIL	Rolling Stones (1968)	Wen, the child who cannot age; arrested time
7	HEAVY METAL QUEEN	The heavy-metal idiom	A trucker's ethic of the road; labour among drifters
8	WALTZ FOR VENUS	Bill Evans, "Waltz for Debby" (first recorded 1956)	A brother's gift of sight to a blind sister; care at the price of a life
9	JAMMING WITH EDWARD	*Jamming with Edward!* (1972 LP)	Ed arrives; a lonely satellite draws geoglyphs on Earth
10	GANYMEDE ELEGY	The elegy	Jet and Alisa; the time that stopped when love left

SESSION	TITLE	CHANGES BORROWED (TITLE SOURCE)	HEAD WRITTEN OVER THEM
11	TOYS IN THE ATTIC	Aerosmith (1975); *Alien* (1979)	Domestic horror of forgotten food; consumption as threat
12	JUPITER JAZZ, PART 1	Jazz as such	Callisto, Gren, Faye's flight; the past speaks Julia's name
13	JUPITER JAZZ, PART 2	Jazz as such	Vicious and Gren; a body launched toward Titan; the head developed
14	BOHEMIAN RHAPSODY	Queen (1975)	The Gates' dismissed architect, who warned of defects, and an endless chess game
15	MY FUNNY VALENTINE	Rodgers and Hart (1937)	Faye's origin: cryosleep, awakening, debt, the con
16	BLACK DOG SERENADE	Led Zeppelin, "Black Dog" (1971)	Jet's arm and his partner's betrayal; the law's rot
17	MUSHROOM SAMBA	The samba	Hunger, hallucination and blaxploitation homage
18	SPEAK LIKE A CHILD	Herbie Hancock (1968)	A Betamax tape from Faye's childhood; obsolete media as memory
19	WILD HORSES	Rolling Stones (1971)	An old mechanic and a museum shuttle; analogue salvage
20	PIERROT LE FOU	Godard (1965)	An engineered child-killer in an amusement park; fear
21	BOOGIE WOOGIE FENG SHUI	Boogie-woogie	Geomancy, a lost father, a fragment of the accident; fate
22	COWBOY FUNK	Funk	Andy, the costume cowboy, and the Teddy Bomber; the double
23	BRAIN SCRATCH	The turntable scratch	A televised cult of disembodiment; the screen as false heaven
24	HARD LUCK WOMAN	KISS (1976)	Faye's ruined home; Ed and Ein leave the ship
25	THE REAL FOLK BLUES, PART 1	Chess LP series (1965–66)	The syndicate's coup; Julia returns
26	THE REAL FOLK BLUES, PART 2	Chess LP series (1965–66)	Julia's death, Vicious's death, Spike's descent; the head restated

Two patterns emerge from the table. The titles cluster around a canon of Anglo-American rock and jazz from roughly 1956 to 1981, the period in which that music's future still seemed open; the series is thus scored, at the level of its paratexts, by the music of a future that did not arrive. And the forms named (blues, shuffle, ballad, elegy, waltz, samba, boogie-woogie, funk) supply a rhythm for each session before its first image. The title is the count-in.

1.9 WHOSE BLUES? BORROWING, AUTHENTICITY AND THE HISTORY THE MUSIC CARRIES

The argument of this chapter rests on a history it must name rather than presume. The blues took form among Black Americans in the Deep South after Emancipation, under sharecropping, debt peonage and the Jim Crow regime of legal segregation, which Southern state governments enforced by law and white mobs enforced by lynching, killing thousands of Black Americans between the 1880s and the mid-twentieth century. Baraka's *Blues People* reads the music as the record of that history. Bebop was made two generations later by Black musicians playing segregated venues for clubs and record labels, mostly white-owned, that often paid them poorly and kept the rights to their recordings. Charlie Parker, its central figure, was addicted to heroin from his teens and died in 1955 at the age of thirty-four. The vocabulary this study borrows (syncope, the swoon, the blues as such) had a literal history in that scene before it became a metaphor here.

The Japanese reception of the music carries a second history. Jazz reached Japan in the interwar dance halls and returned after 1945 with the American Occupation, in clubs that served the occupying forces, Black soldiers among them. E. Taylor Atkins's *Blue Nippon* shows how Japanese musicians and critics then measured authenticity against Black American players, at times essentialising Blackness as the source of a feeling the Japanese could only imitate. The series inherits that authenticity complex along with the music. Its use of the blues as a universal grammar of loss risks the move Baraka warned against, the detachment of a people's music from the people and the oppression that made it; and its blaxploitation homage in Session 17, affectionate as it is, reproduces some of that genre's stereotypes.

The concept of blue parody is offered with this risk in view, and with a debt acknowledged. Ralph Ellison stated a syncopic ontology half a century before the series. In the prologue to *Invisible Man* (1952), his narrator, listening to Louis Armstrong's "(What Did I Do to Be So) Black and Blue," explains that invisibility gives one a slightly different sense of time: one is never quite on the beat, sometimes ahead and sometimes behind, and can slip into the breaks between beats and look around. For Ellison the off-beat is not a style but the temporal condition of a man whom the society around him refuses to see. Whatever the series makes of syncope, the idea was first a Black American account of living inside a structure built to erase.



CHAPTER 2

AFTER THE GATE

Catastrophe, Diaspora and the Exhausted Frontier

> *To live in the anachronotope is to live in syncope: always slightly behind the beat of one's own time, phrasing the present in the idioms of the dead.*

2

2.1 THE DOWNBEAT THAT HAS ALREADY FALLEN
2.2 THE FRONTIER CLOSED, REOPENED, EXHAUSTED
2.3 THE HEAD ECONOMY: BOUNTY, DEBT AND THE PRICE OF PERSONS
2.4 JAPAN BETWEEN THE BUBBLE AND THE GATE
2.5 FŪDO: CLIMATE AS EXISTENTIAL CONDITION
2.6 SMOOTH AND STRIATED SPACE
2.7 MUKOKUSEKI AND THE ODOUR OF THE LOST PLACE
2.8 THE ANACHRONOTOPE

IF THE SESSION SUPPLIES the series' grammar, the Gate Accident supplies its ground. This chapter reads the post-catastrophic solar system on four registers at once: as the closed and reopened frontier of the Western, as a privatised economy of justice in which persons become prices, as an allegory of Japan between the collapse of the asset bubble and the year of the series' production, and as a philosophical geography in which climate, infrastructure and nostalgia shape existence. It ends by proposing a term for the series' peculiar fusion of future and past: the **anachronotope**.

2.1 THE DOWNBEAT THAT HAS ALREADY FALLEN

The catastrophe is narrated sparingly but its consequences are everywhere. An accident in an experimental hyperspace gate in 2022 shattered the Moon; fragments have bombarded Earth ever since, so that the planet's surface is a landscape of craters under a sky of perpetual meteor fall, and most of its population lives underground or has left. Humanity has dispersed across terraformed Mars, Venus, the Jovian moons, Titan and the asteroid belt, linked by a network of gates that make interplanetary travel routine and tolled. The accident is thus both origin and infrastructure: the technology that broke the world is the technology that holds its fragments together.

In the musical terms of Chapter 1, the Gate Accident is the downbeat of the series' history, the strong accent on which every subsequent bar depends. Crucially, it has *already fallen*. None of the protagonists experienced it as an event; they inherit it as a condition, as a key signature. This is the first sense in which the series' ontology is syncopic: its characters live on the weak beats after a strong beat they did not hear. Their accent is displaced from birth. Faye, who was frozen before the catastrophe's long aftermath and woke into it, is the one partial exception, and Chapter 5 shows that her exception is a wound.

Walter Benjamin gave this condition its emblem. In the ninth of his theses "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), written months before he took his own life at Portbou, a German-Jewish refugee fleeing the Nazi occupation of France whose group had been told it would be sent back across the border, he read Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. Its face is turned towards the past, where it sees not a chain of events but one single catastrophe piling wreckage at its feet; it would like to stay and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from paradise drives it irresistibly into the future to which its back is turned, and that storm is what we call progress. The series' fifth session is titled "Ballad of Fallen Angels." Its angels are Benjamin's: they face the wreck of the Moon and are driven backwards into a future assembled from the past, by a storm that began as a triumph of engineering.

2.2 THE FRONTIER CLOSED, REOPENED, EXHAUSTED

In 1893 the historian Frederick Jackson Turner told the American Historical Association that the frontier, the moving line of settlement whose existence had shaped American individualism and democracy, had closed with the census of 1890. The thesis became the founding myth of a discipline and of a genre. Richard Slotkin's trilogy on the American frontier myth (*Regeneration Through Violence*, 1973; *The Fatal Environment*, 1985; *Gunfighter Nation*, 1992) showed how that myth organised American culture around violence as renewal, and how the Western film transmitted it to the twentieth century. Space was later recruited as the "final frontier," a phrase the 1966 television series *Star Trek* made proverbial, so that science fiction could continue the Western by other means.

Cowboy Bebop stages a frontier reopened not by discovery but by disaster. Its space is not virgin territory awaiting the plough but a diaspora of refugees from a broken planet, and its cowboys are not pioneers but scavengers of an order already in decline. Watanabe has said that he stipulated the destruction of the United States decades before the story, because the idea of America as the centre of the world repelled him: this is a Western from which the nation that invented the genre has been subtracted. The series belongs, in this respect, to the late, elegiac phase of the Western: to Sergio Leone's mercenary deconstruction of frontier virtue (the bounty hunters of *Per qualche dollaro in più*, 1965), to Sam Peckinpah's laments for outlaws overtaken by modernity (*The Wild Bunch*, 1969; *Pat Garrett and Billy the Kid*, 1973, whose Bob Dylan song lends the series' film its English title), and to Clint Eastwood's *Unforgiven* (1992), in which the gunfighter's myth is shown to rest on lies, poverty and accident.

Will Wright's structural study of the genre (*Sixguns and Society*, 1975) identified four plot types (classical, vengeance, transition and professional) and argued that the "professional plot," dominant from the late 1950s, depicts heroes who fight as a team of specialists, for pay, apart from a society they no longer represent, finding value only in the competence and loyalty of the group. The Bebop crew is Wright's professional plot carried to its terminus: a team of specialists (pilot, fighter, gambler, hacker, data dog) working for money they rarely receive, apart from a society that consumes their exploits as television. The series adds the twist the genre deferred. Wright's professionals at least got paid; the Bebop's professionals mostly do not, and their group loyalty is never declared, only practised.

2.3 THE HEAD ECONOMY: BOUNTY, DEBT AND THE PRICE OF PERSONS

The police of the solar system, the Inter Solar System Police (ISSP), are overstretched and corruptible, and the series' world has revived the bounty to supplement them. Justice is outsourced to freelancers paid per capture, and its spectacle is packaged by the television programme *Big Shot*, whose hosts, in cowboy costume, bear the names of the English puppet-show couple Punch and Judy. The fusion is exact: law as piecework, justice as entertainment, violence as puppetry. The bounty hunter is the neoliberal subject in its purest form, an entrepreneur of the self whose only capital is skill and whose only product is other people.

The bounty converts persons into prices, and this conversion has a long philosophical shadow. In the second essay of *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887), Nietzsche traced the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) to the material concept of debt (*Schulden*), arguing that punishment originated as a creditor's compensation, the right to inflict suffering in lieu of payment. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) generalised the argument, showing how debt converts obligations between persons into quantified, transferable claims; Maurizio Lazzarato (*La Fabrique de l'homme endetté*, 2011) described indebtedness as the constitutive condition of the neoliberal subject. The series dramatises all three claims. Every bounty is a debt the fugitive owes society, priced in *woolong*; every bounty hunter is in debt (Faye literally, to the medical system that resurrected her; Jet to the memory of a law he served; Spike to the syndicate he fled by staging his own death). Guilt and debt are, as Nietzsche said, the same word.

This economy will be named, in Chapter 10, the ubune economy, after the cormorant fishing whose birds catch what they cannot swallow. Here it suffices to note its material signature: hunger. The series opens on a meal without meat and returns to the motif obsessively; its bounties escape, die, are seized by others, or are lost in collateral damage; its money vanishes in gambling, repairs and fines. The hunters' hunger is not comic decoration but the bodily index of their position in an economy that extracts their labour while denying them its fruit.

2.4 JAPAN BETWEEN THE BUBBLE AND THE GATE

The series was written and animated in 1997 and 1998, and the historical moment presses on it. Japan's asset-price bubble had collapsed at the turn of the decade, inaugurating what would be called the lost decade of stagnant growth, bad debt and diminished prospects for the young. In 1995 the country suffered two shocks that reshaped its imagination of catastrophe: the Great Hanshin earthquake of 17 January, which killed more than six thousand people in and around Kobe, and the release of sarin nerve agent on five Tokyo subway trains during the morning rush hour of 20 March by members of the new religious movement Aum Shinrikyō, acting on the orders of its founder, Asahara Shōkō. The attack killed thirteen people at the time (a fourteenth victim died in 2020) and injured thousands; it revealed a cult of educated young people that had manufactured nerve agents and tried to produce biological weapons in pursuit of apocalypse. Asahara and twelve other members were executed in July 2018. In November 1997 the brokerage Yamaichi Securities collapsed amid the Asian financial crisis.

The series reads, at an allegorical level, as a document of this conjuncture. Its catastrophe is technological rather than natural, caused by an over-ambitious infrastructure project whose risks were known and suppressed (Session 14 reveals that the engineer who designed the gates' central control system warned of design defects and was fired by the Gate Corporation, which built the gates anyway and still conceals the matter; the episode does not say whether those defects caused the 2022 accident). Its terrorists include an eco-militant group, the Space Warriors, led by Twinkle Maria Murdock and armed with a virus that turns human beings into monkeys (Session 4) and a televised cult promising release from the body (Session 23), figures that echo, without allegorising directly, the Aum affair and the fear it seeded of educated youth seduced by transcendence. Its protagonists are casual labourers of a deregulated economy, the spacefaring counterparts of the *furītā* (freeters) who were then becoming a recognised social category. Murakami Haruki, whose non-fiction *Underground* (1997) gathered testimony from the sarin victims, had already made the drifting, jazz-listening, pasta-cooking man whose woman has vanished the signature protagonist of late-twentieth-century Japanese fiction; Chapter 9 returns to the kinship.

2.5 FŪDO: CLIMATE AS EXISTENTIAL CONDITION

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Fūdo* (1935), translated as *Climate and Culture*, was conceived as a response to *Sein und Zeit*. Watsuji admired Heidegger's analysis of human existence as temporal but objected that it neglected spatiality, the way human beings exist outside themselves in a climate, a landscape and a community. He distinguished monsoon, desert and meadow types of *fūdo* and argued that each shapes characteristic modes of feeling and sociality.

The series is a *fūdo*-logy of the diaspora. Each world it visits imposes its ethos. Mars, the metropolitan centre, layers Chinatown, Moroccan souk, Western saloon and Italianate church in a dense palimpsest of transplanted cultures. Venus is a world of floating cities where airborne

spores blind the vulnerable (Session 8). Ganymede is a water world of fishing and sea rats, the climate of Jet's youth and the original home of the Bebop itself, which began as an interplanetary fishing trawler built to work Ganymede's seas. Callisto is a frozen moon whose town, in Session 12, appears to be inhabited only by men, a climate of sexual loneliness and of the war's debris. Io is a desert of hunger and hallucination (Session 17). Titan, never shown in the present, is the climate of a war whose veterans (Gren, Vicious, Vincent of the film) carry it in their bodies. Earth is the climate of ruin: craters, meteor fall, scavengers, children in orphanages, old women who remember. The characters are not only temporally but climatically constituted, and their melancholy is partly the melancholy of people who live in climates their ancestors did not choose.

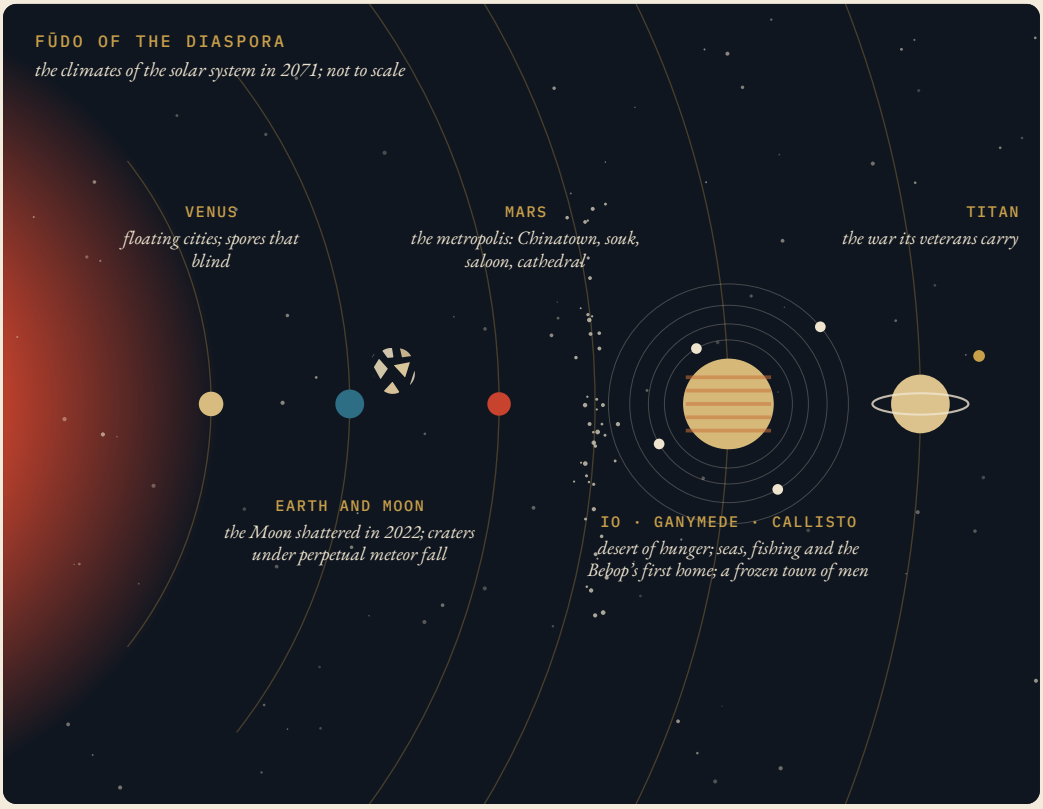


FIG. 2 Fūdo *of the diaspora: the climates of the solar system as Chapter 2 reads them.*

2.6 SMOOTH AND STRIATED SPACE

In *Mille plateaux* (1980), Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari distinguished smooth space (open, intensive, traversed by nomads, of which the sea and the desert are models) from striated space (gridded, measured, channelled by the State, of which the city and the cultivated field are models). The sea, they argued, is the smooth space par excellence and the first to be striated by navigation, cartography and the regulation of routes.

The solar system of the series is smooth space striated by gates. Hyperspace gates channel movement through toll points, owned and policed, so that the apparently boundless void is in practice a network of corridors. Session 4 makes the gate a site of terror; Session 14 reveals that the gate network was built over the objections of the engineer who designed its central control system, whom the Gate Corporation fired when he warned of defects. The Bebop, a fishing vessel from Ganymede's seas transposed to space, is a nomad craft moving through striated space, never free of the gates it needs and never owned by the State it serves. Its crew are semi-nomads: they wander, but along routes; they hunt, but for a bureaucracy; they are outside the law, but on its payroll. The series' sense of freedom is accordingly modest. It is not the freedom of the open range but the freedom of phrasing, of how one moves along corridors one did not build.

2.7 MUKOKUSEKI AND THE ODOUR OF THE LOST PLACE

Iwabuchi Kōichi's concept of *mukokuseki* (literally, the absence of nationality) named the ethnically and culturally unmarked character of many anime exports, a "cultural odourlessness" that eased their global circulation. The series is radically *mukokuseki* on its surface: its protagonists bear names from German, English and invented Asian sources, its cities are composites, its music is international. Yet the concept misses what is most characteristic of the series' hybridity, which is its odour of loss. Its mixture is not the frictionless blend of a global market but the debris of a diaspora, the fragments a scattered people carried from a planet they can no longer inhabit. Edward Said described exile as an unhealable rift between a human being and a native place ("Reflections on Exile," 1984). The series' statelessness is homelessness, and its cosmopolitanism is the cosmopolitanism of refugees. Its culture smells of the lost place, and the smell is the blues.

The director's own account confirms the distinction. Watanabe has said that he wanted the series' world to be "multinational rather than stateless," with its ethnic diversity designed into the planets from the start, and Jonathan Clements and Helen McCarthy (*The Anime Encyclopedia*, revised edition, 2006) characterise its setting as a blend of the Chinese diaspora and the Wild West, weighted two to one towards the West. The hybridity was conceived as a demography rather than a marketing strategy: a population, not a flavour.

2.8 THE ANACHRONOTOPE

Mikhail Bakhtin's essay on the chronotope (written 1937–38, published 1975) defined literary genres by their characteristic fusion of time and space: the road, the castle, the parlour, the threshold. The series has a characteristic chronotope that has puzzled critics: its future of 2071 is furnished with the twentieth century. Its characters smoke, play vinyl and jazz, watch Betamax, drive vintage cars, repair space shuttles from museums, and dress in suits cut for 1960s Hong Kong. This is not merely retro style. It is a temporal thesis.

Mark Fisher, borrowing Jacques Derrida's *hantologie* (*Spectres de Marx*, 1993), argued in *Ghosts of My Life* (2014) that twenty-first-century culture is haunted by "lost futures," the futures promised by twentieth-century modernism that never arrived, so that the present recycles the forms of the past in a "slow cancellation of the future." *Cowboy Bebop* anticipated the diagnosis by more than a decade and dramatised it as setting. Its future is assembled from the futures the twentieth century imagined and lost: the bebop revolution, the space shuttle, the analogue archive, the counterculture. This study calls such a setting an **anachronotope**: a chronotope in which the future is furnished with the past, so that every object is simultaneously a relic and a prophecy. The Bebop itself is the anachronotope's emblem, a second-hand fishing boat flying between planets, named after a music fifty years old in the series' production and a hundred and thirty in its diegesis. To live in the anachronotope is to live in syncope: always slightly behind the beat of one's own time, phrasing the present in the idioms of the dead.



PART TWO · FIGURES

CHAPTER 3

SPIKE SPIEGEL

The Revenant, the Mirror and the Eye

> *Speculative fiction is, etymologically, the fiction of mirrors, and its protagonist here is a mirror that wants to know whether it reflects anyone.*

3

3.1 THE REVENANT
3.2 SPIEGEL: THE MIRROR
3.3 THE EYE AND THE MOMENT: KIERKEGAARD
3.4 BEING-TOWARDS-DEATH: HEIDEGGER
3.5 THE ABSURD AND BAD FAITH: CAMUS AND SARTRE
3.6 IKI: THE AESTHETICS OF COMPOSED DISTANCE
3.7 JEET KUNE DO: FREEDOM AS TIMING
3.8 THE MAN ALREADY DEAD: FROM HAGAKURE TO DEAD MAN
3.9 MELANCHOLIA, REPETITION AND THE REEL: FREUD
3.10 REVENANT TIME

SPIKE SPIEGEL IS A dead man. Before the series begins he left the Red Dragon syndicate by staging his own death, and the syndicate, his former partner and the woman he loved have all lived since in the belief, or the pretence, that he is gone. This chapter argues that his apparent nonchalance, his capacity for sleep, his fluid violence and his final walk are all expressions of one existential situation: the situation of a revenant, a man living in the interval between a death he has performed and a death he has not yet undergone. It reads that situation through five philosophical instruments (Kierkegaard's moment, Heidegger's being-towards-death, the absurd of Camus and the bad faith of Sartre, Kuki Shūzō's *iki*, and Bruce Lee's Jeet Kune Do) and two lineages of the screen (the existential hitman and the man already dead).

3.1 THE REVENANT

The series tells Spike's past through fragments, almost all of them visual and wordless: a stained-glass window, a falling body, rain, a woman's face, a cigarette. The decisive sequence is in Session 5, where Spike, seeking his murdered mentor's killer, enters a ruined cathedral full of white birds, fights Vicious, and falls backwards through the window in slow motion while the image is intercut with memories of an earlier fall. The editing makes the present fall a repetition of a past one, and the episode's title ("Ballad of Fallen Angels") names the condition: Spike is an angel who fell once and keeps falling. Vicious supplies the gloss in the same session, telling Spike that angels thrown out of heaven become devils, and that the same blood runs in both of them, the blood of a wandering beast that hunts the blood of others; when Spike replies that he has bled all such blood away, Vicious asks why, in that case, he is still alive. The question is the series' thesis about Spike in a single line. In Session 26, on the eve of his last confrontation, he explains to Faye that one of his eyes is artificial, that for years he has seen the past through one and the present through the other, and that he has felt himself to be watching a dream from which he could not wake, until he noticed that the dream had already ended. Watanabe has said he insisted on the artificial eye because he wanted every member of the crew to carry a flaw that the story would explore (an eyepatch was considered and vetoed by the producers): the elided beat was a design principle before it was a theme.

The speech is the series' most explicit self-interpretation and it describes revenant time precisely. A revenant (from French *revenir*, to come back) is not a ghost who haunts a place but a dead person who returns among the living and moves among them as if alive. Its time is neither past nor present but a superimposition of both, seen, as Spike says, through two eyes at once. This is why Spike so often seems absent from the scenes he is in, sleeping on the couch while the others argue, gazing at nothing, slipping out of the frame. His lassitude is not laziness but the *syncope* of the revenant: a man repeatedly fainting out of a life he has already officially left.

3.2 SPIEGEL: THE MIRROR

The surname is German for *mirror*, and the series constructs Spike as the centre of a hall of mirrors. Jacques Lacan's account of the mirror stage ("Le stade du miroir," 1949) held that the ego is formed by identification with a specular image whose unity the infant does not possess, so that the self is from the beginning an alienated image, another. Spike's doubles are the series' principal device for showing him to himself. Asimov Solensan in Session 1, wanted for killing members of his own syndicate and stealing a cache of the combat drug Red Eye (Bloody-Eye in the Japanese), flees with his pregnant lover, Katerina; when he reaches for another dose during the final chase, she shoots him, and police cruisers then destroy their ship with her aboard. The first session stages, as a stranger's fate, the ending Spike is moving towards: a flight with a woman, ended by the organisation fled and by the law. Gren, in Sessions 12 and 13, is a war veteran betrayed by Vicious who draws his betrayer to Callisto by invoking Julia's name. Andy, in Session 22, is a costume cowboy so absurdly like Spike in temperament that he mistakes Spike for the bomber he is hunting. Mad Pierrot, in Session 20, is an engineered killer with a child's mind who reduces Spike, for once, to terror. And Vicious is the mirror itself: same school, same training, same woman, same position in the same organisation, differing only in the direction of the gaze.

The hall of mirrors has a precise cinematic source in the climax of Bruce Lee's *Enter the Dragon* (1973), where Lee pursues his enemy into a chamber of mirrors and wins only when he recalls his teacher's counsel that an opponent hides behind images and illusions and is broken when the image is destroyed. Lee shatters the mirrors to find the man. Spike's whole trajectory can be described as the attempt to do the same: to break the image of the past (Julia's face, the syndicate's claim, the mirror that is Vicious) in order to find out whether there is a man behind it. The name *Spiegel* also yields *speculum* and thus *speculation*, the root of the genre's English name. Speculative fiction is, etymologically, the fiction of mirrors, and its protagonist here is a mirror that wants to know whether it reflects anyone.

3.3 THE EYE AND THE MOMENT: KIERKEGAARD

The Danish word for the moment, *Øieblik*, literally means the glance of an eye (as German *Augenblick* means the blink of one). In *Begrebet Angest* (*The Concept of Anxiety*, 1844), Søren Kierkegaard, writing as Vigilius Haufniensis, defined the moment as the ambiguous point at which time and eternity touch, and argued that only in the moment does a human being become a synthesis of the temporal and the eternal, a self rather than a sequence of states. The etymology is more than a pun in the light of Spike's two eyes. A man who sees the past through one eye and the present through the other lacks precisely the single glance in which time and eternity touch. He sees double; he cannot have a moment.

The series supplies a pharmacology of the moment. Red Eye, the combat drug at the centre of Session 1, is taken through the eye, as its name announces, and quickens its user's reflexes until he

can act inside another's movement; it recurs in the Red Dragon arc as the commodity through which Gren lures Vicious to Callisto. Red Eye is the counterfeit *Øieblik*: a purchased glance that accelerates time without uniting it. It delivers its first user in the series not to freedom but to the bullet of the woman he was fleeing with.

Kierkegaard's *Gjentagelsen* (*Repetition*, 1843) supplies the second instrument. Its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, distinguishes recollection, which repeats backward and loves what has been, from repetition, which recollects forward and receives the same thing anew. Recollection is the Greek and melancholy relation to time; repetition is the existential and religious one, demanding that the past be given again rather than merely remembered. Spike's tragedy can be stated in these terms. He wants a repetition (to receive Julia again, to resume the flight that was interrupted) but has only recollection (the fragments of the cathedral and the rain). When Julia returns in the final sessions, she returns as recollection that seems for a moment to become repetition, and she dies on the rooftop before the repetition can take place. Her last words, as rendered in both language tracks, return the series to its master metaphor: it was a dream.

The third instrument is *Sygdommen til Døden* (*The Sickness unto Death*, 1849), in which Anti-Climacus anatomises despair as the self's misrelation to itself. One of its forms is the despair of infinitude, in which the self loses itself in fantasy, becoming volatilised in possibility without the ballast of necessity. Spike's dream is such a fantasy. His indifference is not freedom but a despair that has not yet recognised itself, and the series lets him recognise it only when he tells Faye that the dream is over.

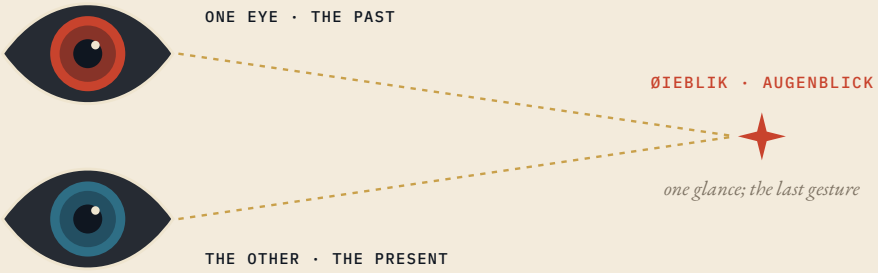


FIG. 3 *Two eyes, two times. Kierkegaard's* Øieblik*, the eye-glance in which time and eternity touch, is what Spike's divided sight lacks until the last gesture.*

3.4 BEING-TOWARDS-DEATH: HEIDEGGER

In *Sein und Zeit* (1927), Martin Heidegger analysed authentic existence as anticipatory resoluteness towards death, which he characterised as Dasein's ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility. The everyday self, absorbed in the anonymous "they" (*das Man*), flees death into idle talk and busyness; the authentic self runs ahead into death as possibility and so takes over its existence as a whole. The authentic present, for Heidegger, is the *Augenblick*, the moment of vision in which resolute Dasein is brought before its situation.

Spike's relation to death parodies this structure. He does not flee death; he is famous for his insouciance in its presence. But he has also not anticipated it in Heidegger's sense, because he has done something stranger: he has converted it from a possibility into a performance. By staging his death, he has placed his ownmost possibility in the past, as an event others believe has occurred, and lives afterwards in a kind of reprieve. This is why his courage looks like indifference: there is nothing at stake in dying for a man who has already died. The final sessions restore death to the future. When Spike leaves the Bebop for the last time, telling Faye in substance that he goes not to die but to find out whether he is really alive, he is choosing resoluteness in Heidegger's sense: taking up death as his own possibility again, so that his existence can become whole. The last word he speaks, a single mimed gunshot, is his *Augenblick*.

This instrument has a history that must be named rather than presumed. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933 and served as rector of the University of Freiburg from April 1933 to April 1934. His rectoral address, *Die Selbstbehauptung der deutschen Universität*, enlisted the vocabulary of resolute existence in the service of the new regime, and the private notebooks published from 2014 as the *Schwarze Hefte* contain antisemitic passages. The resoluteness the series grants Spike is the inverse of that use: not the self-assertion of a people behind a leader but a deserter's decision to meet his own death alone, for no cause. The series takes from Heidegger the structure of authentic finitude and refuses the politics he attached to it.

3.5 THE ABSURD AND BAD FAITH: CAMUS AND SARTRE

Popular commentary aligns Spike with Albert Camus's absurd hero, and the alignment has real purchase. In *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942), Camus defined the absurd as the confrontation between the human demand for meaning and the unreasonable silence of the world, and recommended lucidity without appeal: to live without hope and without resignation, as Sisyphus returns to his rock. The series' English dub gave Spike a refrain ("whatever happens, happens") that sounds like the absurdist creed, and his willingness to roll each bounty up the hill and watch it roll down again is Sisyphean in form. But Camus's hero is lucid, and Spike is dreaming. The absurd requires that one keep the contradiction in view; Spike keeps it at a distance.

Camus's novel *L'Étranger* (1942) offers a closer parallel and a harder one. Its narrator, Meursault, shoots and kills a man on a beach in Algiers, a man the novel calls only "the Arab"

and never names; condemned, he ends by opening himself to the gentle indifference of the world. Kamel Daoud's counter-novel *Meursault, contre-enquête* (2013) gives the dead man a name, Musa, and with it the colonial history on which the original's serenity rests. The comparison clarifies what the series does differently. Its economy converts persons into prices, yet almost every quarry it pursues receives a name, a history and a death that matters: Asimov and Katerina, Wen, Gren, Mad Pierrot, Vincent. The series' calm before death is not bought with the anonymity of the dead.

Jean-Paul Sartre's concept of bad faith (*mauvaise foi*) in *L'Être et le néant* (1943) is more exact. Bad faith is the self-deception by which consciousness denies either its facticity (what it is, has been, cannot change) or its transcendence (its freedom to be otherwise). Spike oscillates between both denials. When he tells Faye that the past does not matter, he denies his facticity; when he drifts as if nothing could be chosen, he denies his transcendence. His final act ends the oscillation by affirming both together: the past matters absolutely (he returns to it), and he chooses absolutely how to meet it (he walks into it).

3.6 IKI: THE AESTHETICS OF COMPOSED DISTANCE

The philosophical instrument most precisely fitted to Spike is Japanese. Kuki Shūzō, who had studied with Heidegger in Germany and taken lessons in Paris from the young Sartre, published *"Iki" no kōzō* (*The Structure of "Iki"*) in 1930. *Iki* named the aesthetic ideal of the late-Edo urban pleasure quarters: a chic, understated, worldly style. Kuki analysed it into three moments. *Bitai* (coquetry) is a dualistic tension towards the other that maintains the possibility of union without consummating it, a distance kept open. *Ikiji* (pride or brave composure) is the spirited self-possession of the Edo townsman, inflected by the warrior ideal. *Akirame* (resignation) is the detachment, schooled by Buddhist insight into impermanence and by disappointment, that frees one from clinging. *Iki*, in Kuki's formula, is coquetry made composed by pride and refined by resignation.

Spike embodies the three moments with unusual exactness. His *bitai* is the open, unconsummated tension of his relation to Faye, a flirtation of insults that both preserve and never close. His *ikiji* is his bearing in danger: the cigarette, the slouch, the refusal to be impressed. His *akirame* is his detachment from money, from comfort, from the future. Kuki's analysis also explains what destroys him. *Iki* depends on distance; the moment one clings, the style collapses into vulgar attachment or tragic passion. Julia is the one relation Spike cannot hold at an *iki* distance. She is not coquetry but fate, and the series' tragedy is the story of *iki* undone by a single attachment it could not refine away. Kuki, notably, also lectured at Pontigny in 1928 on time and repetition in Eastern thought, contrasting Buddhist cyclic time with the eternal recurrence of Nietzsche; Chapter 10 returns to that bridge.

Kuki's analysis has a history it does not name. *Iki* was the style of the licensed pleasure quarters, above all the Yoshiwara in Edo, whose courtesans were typically bound by indenture: sold

into service as girls by families in debt, held by brothel-keepers to terms of years, and kept there by debts that grew while they worked. Kuki aestheticised the coquetry of women whose labour was mortgaged, and Leslie Pincus has shown how *The Structure of "Iki"* constructed from that culture a timeless national essence that the ideologues of empire could use (*Authenticating Culture in Imperial Japan*, 1996). Read against this history, the series' distribution of *iki* is pointed. Its most coquettish figure, Faye, is a woman bound by a debt she did not incur, and the style Spike wears as freedom is, in her, the performance of a debtor. The ubune economy of Chapter 10 has an Edo precedent.

3.7 JEET KUNE DO: FREEDOM AS TIMING

Spike's fighting style is modelled on Bruce Lee's Jeet Kune Do, "the way of the intercepting fist," and his evident devotion to Lee is a recurring detail. Lee, who studied philosophy at the University of Washington, synthesised Wing Chun, Western boxing and fencing with readings in Daoism, Zen and Jiddu Krishnamurti. His emblem bears the maxim 以無法為有法，以無限為有限, which may be rendered: take no way as the way, take no limit as the limit. The posthumous *Tao of Jeet Kune Do* (1975) assembles his notes on formlessness, adaptability and the rejection of fixed styles. Lee's philosophy of combat is a philosophy of timing: the intercepting fist strikes into the interval of the opponent's intention, before the attack is complete.

This is improvisation translated into the body, and it links Spike's violence to the series' jazz grammar. Spike fights as a bebop soloist phrases: off the beat, inside the other's line, with economy and surprise. His movements are frequently choreographed as dance (Lee himself had been a cha-cha champion in Hong Kong), and the animation renders them with a weightless fluidity that contrasts with Jet's mass. Jeet Kune Do's emphasis on formlessness is the martial form of the *ma* that Chapter 10 will place at the centre of the series' ontology: freedom located not in force but in the interval.

3.8 THE MAN ALREADY DEAD: FROM HAGAKURE TO DEAD MAN

The samurai treatise *Hagakure* (dictated by Yamamoto Tsunetomo, c. 1709–1716) opens its first book with the claim that the way of the warrior is found in death, and counsels the retainer to rehearse his death each morning so that he may live as one already dead (*shinimi*) and thereby be free. Mishima Yukio's *Hagakure nyūmon* (1967) made the text a manifesto of aestheticised death; three years later its author acted on it, as the next paragraph records. Spike is a literalisation of *shinimi*: a man who lives freely because he has already died. The difference is decisive. The *Hagakure* retainer rehearses death in service of a lord; Spike rehearsed it to escape one. His freedom is the freedom of the deserter, not of the vassal, and the final sessions are his return to the service he deserted, not as loyalty but as reckoning.

The vassal's death ethic has a modern history that this distinction must face. *Hagakure* was largely forgotten for two centuries; first printed in a modern edition in 1900, it became a canonical book of the samurai only in the era of the Pacific War, when it was widely read by Japanese soldiers as a guide to warrior ethics and its equation of the warrior's way with death was enlisted in appeals to die for the emperor. The standard Iwanami edition was co-edited by Watsuji Tetsurō, whose ethics Chapter 4 employs. Mishima carried the ethic to its end. On 25 November 1970, with four members of his private militia, the Tatenokai, he took the commanding general hostage at the Ichigaya headquarters of the Ground Self-Defense Force's Eastern Army in Tokyo, urged the assembled soldiers from a balcony to rise in a coup that would restore sovereignty to the emperor, and, when they jeered him, died by ritual suicide (*seppuku*), as did the Tatenokai member Morita Masakatsu. Spike's desertion is the series' answer to that lineage: the man who lives as one already dead does so, here, in order to escape a lord, and his last act serves no throne.

Three films of the screen's existential-hitman lineage bracket the series. Jean-Pierre Melville's *Le Samouraï* (1967) opens with an invented maxim attributed to a book of *bushidō* and follows a silent contract killer whose last act is to walk into his own death with an empty gun. John Woo's *The Killer* (1989) and *A Better Tomorrow* (1986) supplied the series' iconography of church gunfights, white doves, sworn brotherhood and betrayal. And Jim Jarmusch, in the same years as the series, made *Dead Man* (1995), whose protagonist, shot early in the film, journeys westward towards a death that has already begun, and *Ghost Dog: The Way of the Samurai* (1999), whose hitman reads *Hagakure*. *Dead Man* is the closest analogue: a Western in which the hero is a revenant from the first reel, and in which the whole journey is the slow completion of a death. Spike's twenty-six sessions are the same journey told in jazz time.

3.9 MELANCHOLIA, REPETITION AND THE REEL: FREUD

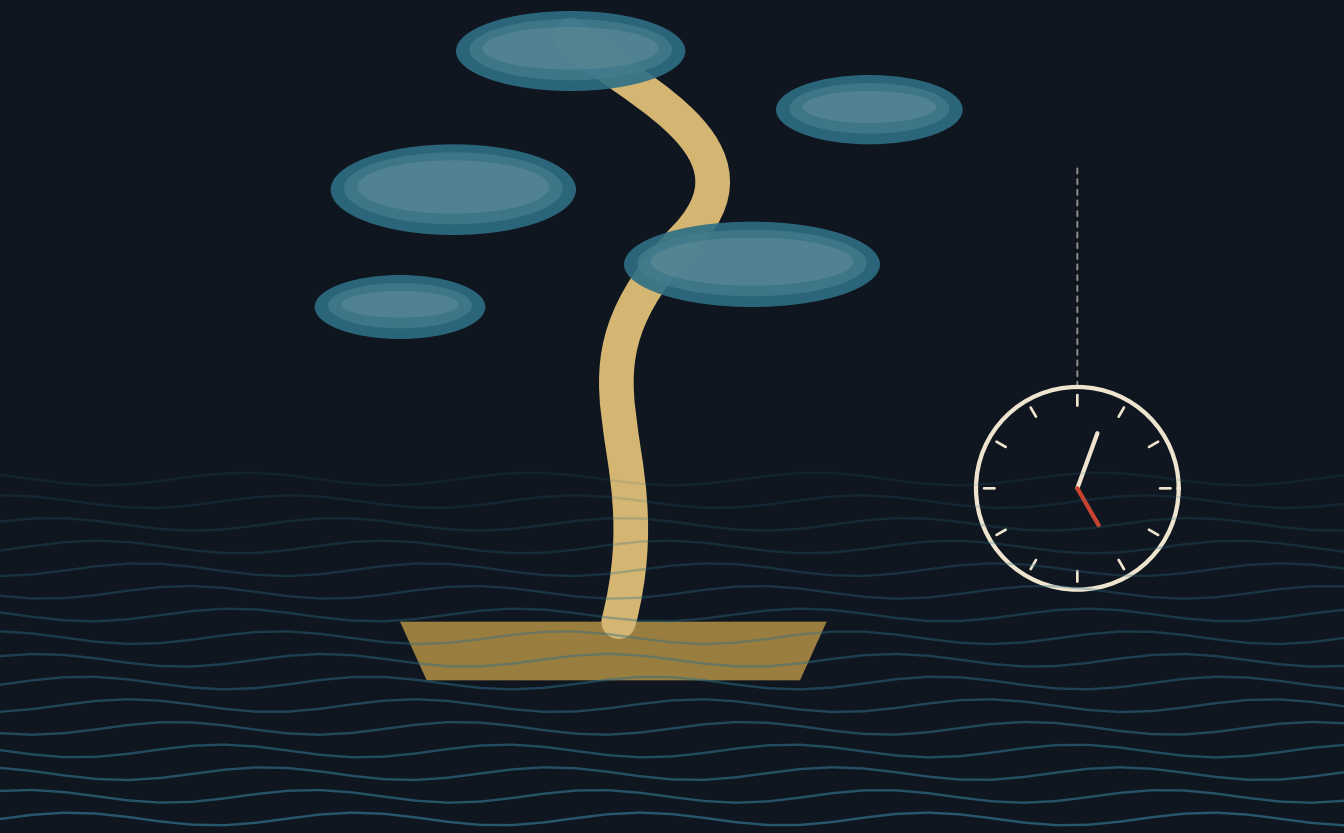
Freud supplies the clinical name for revenant time. In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) he distinguished mourning, in which the ego, tested against reality, withdraws its attachment from a lost object piece by piece until it is free again, from melancholia, in which the loss is withdrawn from consciousness and the lost object is taken into the ego itself, so that, in his phrase, *der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich*: the shadow of the object fell upon the ego. The melancholic knows whom he has lost but not what he has lost in them, and the loss returns as an impoverishment of the self. Spike's lassitude, his indifference and his habit of sleep are melancholia in this exact sense: Julia's shadow has fallen on him and become his manner.

"Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" (1914) adds that a patient who cannot remember repeats, acting out what he has forgotten instead of recalling it, until working-through ends the repetition. The sessions are Spike's repetitions (the falls, the duels, the women in flight, the bounties that escape); Julia's return is remembering; the final walk is a working-through, though not of a kind any clinic would recommend. *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) supplies the last term.

Freud watched his eighteen-month-old grandson throw a wooden reel on a string out of sight with a long cry that the adults heard as *fort* (gone), and pull it back with a joyful *da* (there): the child mastered his mother's absences by staging them. From compulsions to repeat that exceed any pleasure, Freud inferred a drive towards an earlier, inanimate state, and concluded that the aim of all life is death. The series grants the inference and refuses its fatalism. Spike's death is not the drive's victory but the end of repetition by an act, and its mechanism is the one Chapter 10 calls heterodox release: Julia's death turns melancholia into mourning, and Spike's mourning completes itself not by letting go but by following.

3.10 REVENANT TIME

The instruments converge. Kierkegaard shows that Spike lacks a moment because he sees with two eyes. Heidegger shows that he has displaced his death into the past and so lives in reprieve. Sartre shows that the reprieve is bad faith. Kuki shows that his style is *iki* and that *iki* breaks on Julia. Lee shows that his freedom is timing, not force. Freud shows that his repetitions are the work of a melancholia that only mourning can end. *Hagakure*, Melville and Jarmusch show that the man already dead is free, and that his freedom ends when he chooses to finish dying. Spike's temporality is therefore neither the absurd present of Camus nor the anticipatory future of Heidegger but revenant time: the time of the interval between two deaths. The series' last session is not about whether he will die but about how he will close the interval, and its answer, read in Chapter 10, is that he closes it as a musician closes a phrase.



CHAPTER 4

JET BLACK

The Gardener of a Ruined Law

> *The Black Dog unclenches his jaw.*

4.1 THE BLACK DOG
4.2 CAPTAIN OF A FISHING BOAT
4.3 THE GARDENER AFTER LISBON
4.4 THE KITCHEN AND THE MISSING BEEF
4.5 CARE AND ITS SHADOW
4.6 AIDAGARA: THE ETHICS OF BETWEENNESS
4.7 THE OZU FATHER
4.8 THE TIME OF MAINTENANCE

4

JET BLACK IS THE series' ethical subject, as Spike is its existential one. Where Spike lives in revenant time, Jet lives in the time of maintenance: the slow time of the garden, the kitchen, the engine room and the promise kept. This chapter argues that Jet embodies an ethics of care that survives the collapse of the institution it once served, and that the series both honours this ethics and exposes its shadow, paternalism, through the one relationship in which Jet's care became control.

4.1 THE BLACK DOG

Jet was a detective of the ISSP on his home moon of Ganymede, where his tenacity earned him the nickname Black Dog: once he bit, he did not let go. His left arm is a prosthesis, the residue of an operation in which his partner, Fad, betrayed him to the hitman Udai Taxim, who took the arm, and, as the series later reveals, a mechanical limb he chose over a biological replacement so that it would remind him; Session 16, "Black Dog Serenade," returns him to that betrayal years later, aboard a prison ship seized by its convicts, and ends with Jet killing the partner who had sold him. He left the force not because he ceased to believe in law but because the law ceased to deserve belief.

The nickname places Jet in the series' bestiary of domesticated hunters. The dog is the animal that hunts for a master and returns its catch; the police dog is the State's hunter. Jet is a dog who left his master but kept the master's code, a hound hunting on his own account for the rewards of an institution he no longer trusts. In Dashiell Hammett's *The Maltese Falcon* (1930), Sam Spade explains, at the novel's end, that when a man's partner is killed he is supposed to do something about it, whatever he thought of the partner. Jet's ethic is Spade's ethic turned inside out: his partner did not die but betrayed, and Jet's code compels him to finish what the betrayal began. Raymond Chandler's portrait of the detective as an honourable man walking corrupt streets without being corrupted ("The Simple Art of Murder," 1944) describes Jet more closely than any character in the series, which is why the series gives him so little glamour. Honour, in its world, is a form of hard labour.

4.2 CAPTAIN OF A FISHING BOAT

Jet bought the Bebop second-hand. It was built as an interplanetary fishing trawler to work Ganymede's seas; he fitted it with larger engines and new communications and named it after the music of Charlie Parker, whom he reveres. His personal craft, the Hammerhead, carries the same maritime heritage (a modified salvage craft whose harpoon-tipped mechanical arm echoes his own), and his signature weapon is a net-gun. The captain of the bounty hunters is thus, materially, a fisherman, and the ship that carries Spike's Swordfish and Jet's Hammerhead is a boat built to catch fish, carrying craft named after fish. Chapter 10 builds on this detail its account of the series as a cormorant-boat; here it is enough to note that Jet's role on board is the fisherman's: he steers, maintains, mends nets, cooks the catch, and waits.

4.3 THE GARDENER AFTER LISBON

Jet keeps bonsai, and the series frequently finds him pruning them while the others quarrel. Bonsai is an art of patient constraint: the cultivator shapes a living tree over years, removing growth so that the plant may express, in miniature, the form of an old tree exposed to weather. It is care as discipline, and it requires a relation to time radically unlike the bounty hunter's. The bounty pays now or never; the bonsai pays in decades.

The philosophical genealogy of Jet's garden runs through Voltaire. The Lisbon earthquake of 1755, which destroyed one of Europe's great cities on All Saints' Day, shattered the optimistic theodicy associated with Leibniz and Pope, and Voltaire answered it first with the *Poème sur le désastre de Lisbonne* (1756) and then with *Candide* (1759). After a picaresque of catastrophes, Candide rejects Pangloss's metaphysical consolation and concludes that we must cultivate our garden. The counsel is not quietism but a reorientation from cosmic justification to local work. The Gate Accident is the series' Lisbon, a catastrophe that discredited the faith in progress embodied by its own technology. Jet is Candide after Lisbon: a man who has seen through the institutions that promised justice and has turned to cultivating what can be cultivated, a few trees, a ship, a dinner, a crew.

4.4 THE KITCHEN AND THE MISSING BEEF

Jet cooks. His signature dish is bell peppers and beef (*chinjāo rōsu*), which, for want of money, routinely arrives without the beef. The joke is structural. The kitchen is the place where the household (*oikos*) reproduces itself, and Jet's cooking is the economy (*oikonomia*, household management) of the Bebop in its most literal form. The missing beef is the elided beat of that economy: the substance the dish is named for and cannot contain. The crew eats the name of a meal. Syncope in the grammatical sense (the elision of a sound from within a word) has here its culinary equivalent, and the series' refusal to supply the beef is a refusal to let its characters' hunger be resolved by a single success.

Hannah Arendt's distinction in *The Human Condition* (1958) among labour (the cyclical activity that sustains biological life and leaves nothing behind), work (the fabrication of durable things) and action (the initiation of new beginnings among others) clarifies Jet's position. Jet is the crew's labourer and worker: he cooks, cleans, repairs and gardens, the activities that sustain a common life and leave little trace. Spike is the crew's actor, though his action, unlike Arendt's natal beginnings, is directed towards an end. The series' sympathy for Jet is the sympathy of a work that knows it would collapse without labour, and that labour is seldom thanked.

4.5 CARE AND ITS SHADOW

The ethics of care, articulated by Carol Gilligan (*In a Different Voice*, 1982), Nel Noddings (*Caring*, 1984) and Joan Tronto (*Moral Boundaries*, 1993), locates moral life not in abstract principles of justice but in concrete relations of attentiveness, responsibility, competence and responsiveness. Tronto's four phases (caring about, taking care of, care-giving and care-receiving) describe Jet's practice almost exactly: he notices, assumes responsibility, does the work, and attends to how it is received. He nurses Spike after the cathedral, rescues Faye repeatedly, feeds Ed and Ein, and tolerates a household that rarely acknowledges him.

Session 10, "Ganymede Elegy," exposes the shadow of this care. Jet returns to Ganymede and finds Alisa, the woman who left him years before without explanation, running a failing bar called La Fin ("the end") and involved with a wanted man, Rhint Celonias. Jet has carried a pocket watch since she left, stopped at the hour of her departure; she left behind only a watch and a note of farewell. When he asks why she left, she first deflects: it was a lifetime ago, and time does not stand still. Only at the end, with a pistol in her hand, does she give the reason: he protected her too much and would not let her be her own person. Care, in Jet, had become control. Tronto's fourth phase, attention to how care is received, is the one Jet had failed, and the failure is figured as arrested time.

The episode resolves without violence, which is rare in the series. Jet arrests Rhint, lets Alisa go, and, walking away, throws the stopped watch into the water. The gesture inverts a famous object of the Western. In Leone's *Per qualche dollaro in più*, a chiming pocket watch holds the photograph of a murdered woman and times the final duel in which her brother takes his revenge; the watch contains arrested trauma and releases it through killing. Jet's watch contains the same arrested time, and he releases it by letting go. The Black Dog unclenches his jaw.

4.6 AIDAGARA: THE ETHICS OF BETWEENNESS

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Rinrigaku* (*Ethics*, 1937–49) argued that the Japanese word for a human being, *ningen* (人間), written with the characters for person and between, discloses that human existence is constituted not in isolated individuals but in *aidagara*, betweenness: the network of relations in which persons exist as son and father, colleague, neighbour, lover. Ethics, for Watsuji, is the study of betweenness, and its dynamic is a double negation in which the individual negates the community to assert itself and the community negates the individual to sustain itself.

Jet is the series' subject of *aidagara*. Every identity he holds is relational (former partner, former lover, captain, cook, surrogate father), and his crisis is the failure of the betweenness that defined him: the partnership betrayed, the love departed, the institution corrupted. The Bebop is his attempt to rebuild a betweenness from the debris. It is the most fragile kind (unsworn, unpaid, uncontracted), and the series' last movement dissolves it. But Watsuji's account helps ex-

plain why the dissolution is grievous rather than merely sad: if the self is between, then the end of the crew is the end of a self.

Watsuji's ethics has a political history that its use here must reckon with. *Rinrigaku* culminates in the state as the highest form of betweenness; in the war years Watsuji wrote in support of the imperial system, notably in *Sonnō shisō to sono dentō* (*Reverence for the Emperor and Its Tradition*, 1943), and he co-edited the standard Iwanami edition of *Hagakure*. Robert Bellah argued in 1965 that Watsuji's ethics leaves the individual no standpoint from which to refuse the totality. The Bebop answers that objection by its form. Its betweenness has no state, no emperor and no obligation to remain; every member is free to walk away, and Spike, Ed and Ein do.

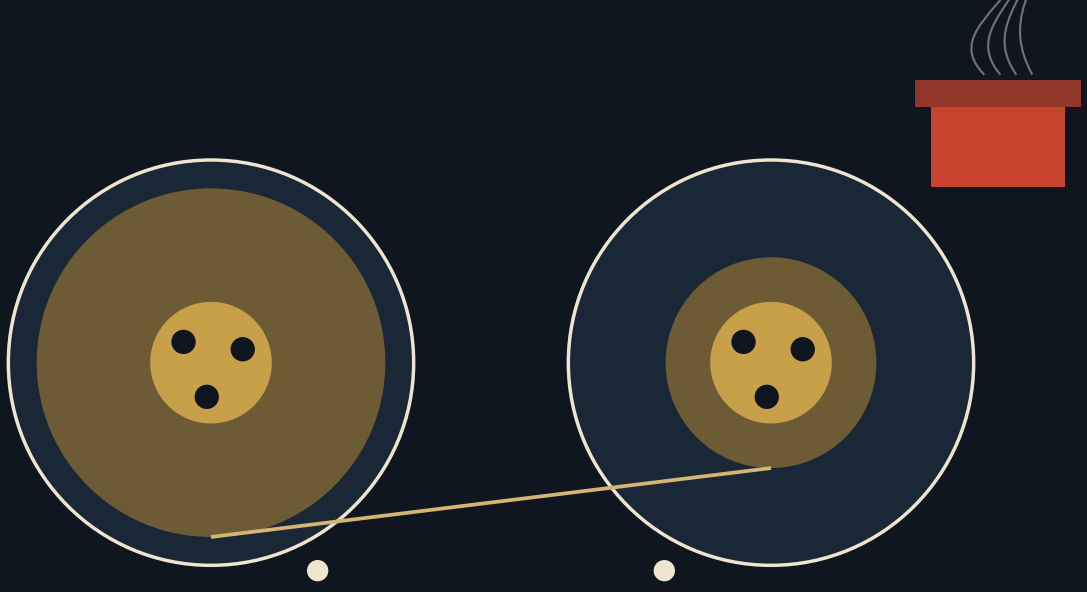
4.7 THE OZU FATHER

Jet's relation to Ed belongs to a lineage the series does not cite but unmistakably inhabits: the fathers of Ozu Yasujirō. In *Banshun* (*Late Spring*, 1949), a widowed professor contrives his daughter's marriage, and the film ends with him alone, peeling an apple, his head bowing. In *Tōkyō monogatari* (*Tokyo Story*, 1953), aged parents are gently neglected by children absorbed in their own lives. Ozu's cinema is the classic modern expression of *mono no aware*, the poignant awareness of the transience of things that Motoori Norinaga identified as the core of Japanese literary sensibility in the eighteenth century.

Session 24 is the series' Ozu episode. Ed finds her father, departs with Ein, and leaves the Bebop to the two men. The episode does not dramatise Jet's grief; it shows Spike and Jet at the table, eating hard-boiled eggs in silence. The elision is Ozu's: feeling displaced onto an action too ordinary to bear it, held at the edge of the frame. Jet is the father who lets go, as he let go of Alisa's watch, and the series lets the gesture be its own commentary.

4.8 THE TIME OF MAINTENANCE

Jet's temporality, in sum, is the cyclical time of maintenance and the slow time of growth: the meal that must be cooked again tomorrow, the engine that must be repaired again next week, the tree that will take years to shape. It is the time the bounty economy cannot price, and it is the time that holds the crew together. In the musical terms of Chapter 1, Jet is the rhythm section: the bassist who keeps the changes so that the soloists can leave them, and who is noticed only when he stops. His ethic is the condition of possibility of everyone else's freedom, and the series, which ends on Spike's solo, knows that the solo depends on the bass.



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CHAPTER 5

FAYE VALENTINE

Urashima's Daughter

> *Home has migrated from a place to an ensemble.*

5.1 A REST OF FIFTY-FOUR YEARS
5.2 URASHIMA'S DAUGHTER
5.3 THE SLEEPER WITHOUT A PRINCE
5.4 THE GAMBLER WITHOUT EXPERIENCE
5.5 HABIT WITHOUT HISTORY: BERGSON
5.6 THE TAPE AND THE AURA
5.7 NACHTRÄGLICHKEIT AND THE FAILED HOMECOMING
5.8 THE FEMME FATALE UNMADE
5.9 ANACHRONIC TIME

5

FAYE VALENTINE IS THE series' anachronic subject: biologically in her early twenties, chronologically in her seventies, and possessed of no memory of the life that separates the two figures. This chapter reads her as the series' most radical experiment in time, a woman whose existence contains a rest fifty-four years long, and argues that her story inverts three inherited narratives (the Japanese tale of Urashima Tarō, the European fairy tale of the sleeper awakened, and the Homeric homecoming) in order to propose a fourth: home as an ensemble rather than a place.

5.1 A REST OF FIFTY-FOUR YEARS

Session 15, "My Funny Valentine," discloses her origin. As a young woman she was gravely injured in a shuttle accident and, because the medicine of the day could not treat her, placed in cryogenic suspension. She was revived fifty-four years later with no memory of her former life, given a name, and presented with the bill for her preservation and treatment. A smooth-talking man who presented himself as her protector, Whitney Hagas Matsumoto, then staged his own death and left her saddled with his debts as well. By simple arithmetic she was frozen before the Gate Accident: she is the only member of the crew to have lived on an intact Earth, and she does not remember it.

In musical notation a rest is not an absence but a measured silence, a duration that belongs to the music. Faye's life contains a rest of fifty-four years, and the series treats it in exactly that way: not as a gap that can be ignored but as a silence that changes the meaning of everything around it. She re-enters the piece late and in the wrong key, and her signature behaviours (gambling, lying, flight, abrupt loyalty) are the improvisations of a player who has lost the changes.

The detail of Whitney's staged death is structurally important and rarely remarked. Faye's betrayer did to her what Spike did to the Red Dragon: he faked his death to escape what he owed and left others to carry it. The series thus mirrors its two protagonists across a single act. Spike is the one who faked a death; Faye is the one who paid for a faked death. Their relationship, all quarrel and unconsummated tension, is the relation between a debtor and a creditor who do not know they are bound by the same instrument.

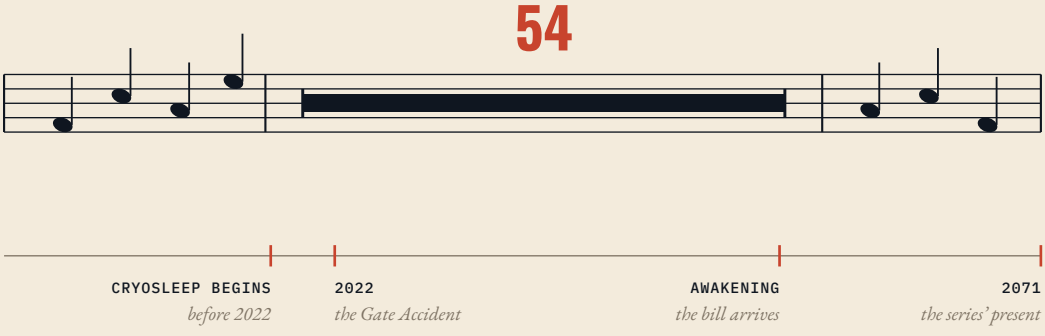


FIG. 4 *A rest of fifty-four years, in the notation of a multi-measure rest: a silence that belongs to the music. Schematic.*

5.2 URASHIMA'S DAUGHTER

The Japanese tale of Urashima Tarō is the oldest narrative of anachronic return in the literature. In the earliest versions (the *Nihon shoki* of 720 and a fragment of the *Tango no kuni fūdoki*), a fisherman of Mizunoe is taken to an immortal realm across the sea; a poem in the *Man'yōshū* (book 9) laments his return. In the later form fixed in the Muromachi-period *otogizōshi*, he rescues a turtle, is carried to the Dragon Palace (*Ryūgū-jō*) beneath the sea, lives there for what seem a few days with the princess Otohime, and returns home with a lacquered box (*tamatebako*) he is told never to open. His village is unrecognisable, centuries have passed, and when he opens the box a white smoke escapes and he becomes, at once, an old man.

Faye is Urashima's daughter, and the inheritance is precise in three respects. First, the structure: a sojourn outside time (cryosleep) and a return to a world that has moved on by decades. Second, the box: in Session 18, "Speak Like a Child," a Betamax tape arrives addressed to her, and Spike and Jet scour the ruins of Earth for a machine that can play it. The tape is her *tamatebako*; when it is opened, time catches up with her. Third, the palace: in the later tradition Urashima's otherworld is the *Dragon* Palace, and the series' otherworld of attachment and timelessness is the Red *Dragon*, whose gravitational pull Faye experiences only through Spike. The inversion is as telling as the inheritance. Urashima's box ages him instantly into his true chronological age; Faye's box returns her to the child she was. Urashima loses his youth by opening the box; Faye recovers a childhood she had lost. And Urashima was a fisherman, as the Bebop was a fishing boat.

5.3 THE SLEEPER WITHOUT A PRINCE

The European counterpart is the sleeper awakened. Washington Irving's "Rip Van Winkle" (1819) wakes after twenty years to find that a revolution has replaced the king's portrait with Washington's; Charles Perrault's "La Belle au bois dormant" (1697) sleeps a hundred years until a prince arrives. Faye's awakening is the capitalist rewriting of both. She wakes not to a changed political sign but to a changed currency, not to a prince but to an invoice. The figure who appears at her bedside in the role of the prince, solicitous and charming, is a confidence man whose kindness is the opening move of a swindle. The fairy tale's promise (that one wakes into love) is converted into its neoliberal truth (that one wakes into debt). Faye's cynicism is not a character flaw but the reasonable epistemology of a woman whose first experience of the world was a con.

5.4 THE GAMBLER WITHOUT EXPERIENCE

Faye gambles compulsively, and the series introduces her (Session 3) through a casino. Walter Benjamin, in "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939), drew a famous analogy between the gambler and the factory worker: both perform a sequence of discrete moves, each starting afresh without reference to the last, so that their time is a series of shocks without the cumulative continuity Benjamin called *Erfahrung* (experience in the sense of accumulated, transmissible wisdom) as opposed to *Erlebnis* (the isolated lived moment). The gambler wants to win everything back in a single move because he has no past that could be redeemed gradually.

Faye is the gambler as Benjamin described him, with the difference that her loss of *Erfahrung* is literal. She has no accumulated past, only a succession of *Erlebnisse* since her awakening, and her compulsion to gamble is the compulsion of a subject who can relate to time only as chance. Every hand is an attempt to pay off a debt she did not incur with a fortune she does not believe in. That she is good at it (her hands, like her piloting and her shooting, remember skills her mind has lost) introduces the next instrument.

5.5 HABIT WITHOUT HISTORY: BERGSON

Henri Bergson's *Matière et mémoire* (1896) distinguished two forms of memory. Habit-memory is the body's acquired capacity to act, stored as motor mechanism and repeated without being recalled as past. Pure memory (*souvenir pur*) is the survival of the past in itself, as a virtual whole from which particular recollections are drawn when an image in the present calls them forth. Bergson's celebrated cone represents the whole past as a cone resting on its tip, the present point of action, with recollection as a movement from the base towards the tip.

Faye is habit without history. Her body plays cards, flies, fights and lies with fluent competence; her pure memory is sealed. The series locates her recovery exactly where Bergson would: in an image that solicits recollection. In Session 18 the image is the tape, on which her childhood self, recorded for a school project, cheers on the adult she will become. Wordsworth wrote that the child is father of the man ("My Heart Leaps Up," 1802); the tape enacts the proposition literally. The girl encourages the woman she cannot imagine, and the woman watches herself be encouraged by a stranger who is herself.

5.6 THE TAPE AND THE AURA

Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) argued that mechanical reproduction withers the *aura*, the unique presence of an object in time and space. The tape reverses the argument. For Faye, the mechanical reproduction is the only remaining trace of her own unique presence; the reproduction has become auratic precisely because the original (her childhood, her Earth) is irrecoverable. The obsolescence of the medium intensifies the effect. Betamax, the format that lost the videotape war of the 1980s, is itself a ruin; to play it, the crew must excavate a machine from the debris of Earth. Friedrich Kittler's *Grammophon Film Typewriter* (1986) argued that storage media determine what a culture can remember; Faye's memory is held hostage by a dead format. Jacques Derrida's *Mal d'archive* (1995) described the archive as both the condition and the threat of memory, since what is consigned to it can be lost with it. Faye's self survives as a consignment in an archive that almost no longer exists.

5.7 NACHTRÄGLICHKEIT AND THE FAILED HOMECOMING

Freud's concept of *Nachträglichkeit* (deferred action, or in Jean Laplanche's translation, "afterwardsness"), developed from the *Entwurf* of 1895 to the case history of the Wolf Man (1918), holds that a memory acquires its traumatic meaning only later, when a subsequent experience retroactively invests it. Faye's past works this way. Its meaning arrives after the fact: the tape triggers recollection, recollection triggers return, and return reveals that what she has recovered is the memory of a world that no longer exists.

Session 24, "Hard Luck Woman," stages the return as a failed *nostos*. In the *Odyssey*, the homecoming hero is recognised by his old dog Argos, who dies on seeing him, and by the scar his nurse finds while washing his feet; Erich Auerbach's *Mimesis* (1946) opens with that scar as the emblem of a narrative style in which everything is brought into the foreground. Faye's return has no Argos and no scar. She finds a classmate who has aged into an old woman while she slept, and she finds her house reduced to its foundations; the episode ends with her lying on the bare concrete, as if to fit herself into the plan of a home that is no longer there. Her past, unlike Odysseus's, is all background, "fraught with background" in Auerbach's phrase for the biblical style he contrasted with Homer. C. P. Cavafy's "Ithaka" (1911) consoles its traveller that Ithaka gave him the journey and has nothing more to give. Faye's Ithaka gives her less: the knowledge that the journey is all there is.

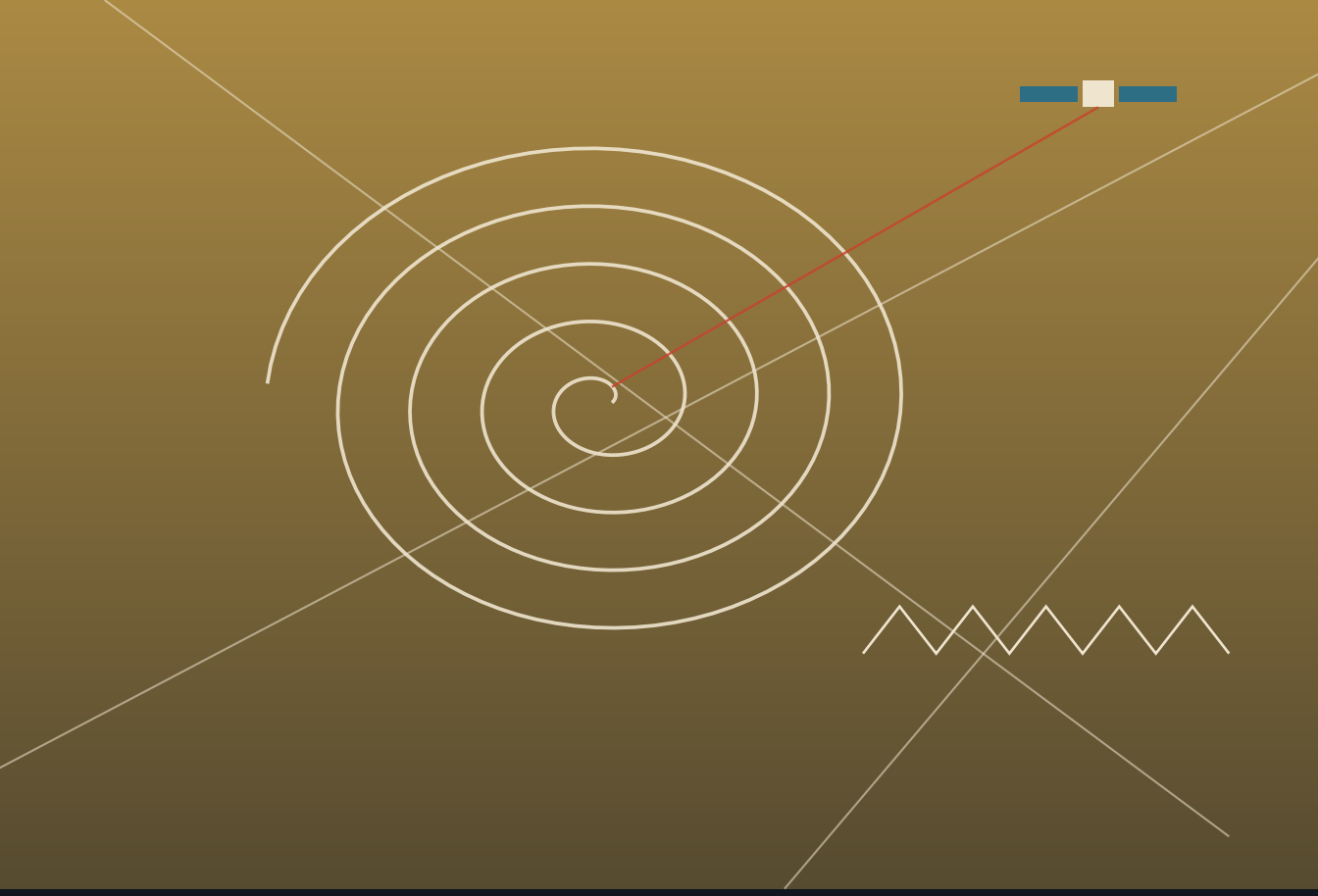
The consequence is the series' only successful homecoming, and it is not the one her nostalgia sought. In the final session Faye tells Spike that when her memory returned she found she had nowhere to go, and that the only place she could come back to was the Bebop. Home has migrated from a place to an ensemble. It is not where she began but where she is accompanied.

5.8 THE FEMME FATALE UNMADE

Faye's design draws on the *femme fatale* of film noir, whom Mary Ann Doane (*Femmes Fatales*, 1991) analysed as an epistemological threat, the woman whose surface conceals a truth that the narrative must expose and punish. The design also invites the critique Laura Mulvey made of classical cinema's organisation around the male gaze ("Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema," 1975). The series does not escape that critique at the level of image, but its narrative unmakes the type. The woman who appears as the con-artist is revealed as the victim of a con; the surface concealing a dark truth conceals instead an absence, a missing past; and the narrative exposes her not to punish her but to give her back her childhood. Judith Butler's account of gender as the sedimented effect of repeated performance (*Gender Trouble*, 1990) illuminates the mechanism: Faye performs the *femme fatale* as a costume chosen by someone who had to invent a self from nothing, and the series lets the costume be seen as costume.

5.9 ANACHRONIC TIME

Faye's temporality is anachronic in the strict sense: it runs against time in both directions. She is older than everyone and younger than everyone; she owes a debt to the past and has no credit with the future; she has a body that remembers and a mind that does not. Her syncope is the longest in the series, a rest of fifty-four years, and her re-entry into the music is the most dissonant. Yet she is also the character who makes the most of the series' one consolation. Spike leaves to finish dying; Ed leaves to find a father; Jet stays because staying is what he does. Faye returns, having discovered that the place she came from no longer exists, to the only place that has made room for her. In the terms of Chapter 10, she is the figure in whom the ethics of comping becomes visible as a home.



CHAPTER 6

EDWARD AND EIN

The Net, the Dog and the Ludic Remainder

> *In the household of a man named Mirror, the silent animal named One is the witness who completes the number.*

6.1 THE CHILD OF THE NET
6.2 THE SATELLITE THAT DREW ON THE EARTH
6.3 PLAY: HUIZINGA, CAILLOIS, SCHILLER
6.4 THE FATHER WHO MAPS CRATERS
6.5 EIN: THE GAZE OF THE OVERLOOKED
6.6 THE LUDIC REMAINDER AND THE TURN TO REQUIEM

6

EDWARD AND EIN ARE the members of the crew the series cannot keep. A child hacker and a genetically enhanced dog, they bring into the household two things the bounty economy does not value and the tragedy at the series' centre cannot accommodate: play and animality. This chapter argues that their arrival completes the ensemble and that their departure in Session 24 is the hinge on which the series turns from comedy to requiem.

6.1 THE CHILD OF THE NET

Ed, a girl of about thirteen from Earth, styles herself Edward Wong Hau Pepelu Tivrusky IV, a name of her own invention whose grandiosity is part of its joke; the name her father gave her is Françoise. She is androgynous in dress and manner, speaks of herself in the third person, moves by rolling, spinning and crawling, and is at home in the network as nowhere else. She enters the series in Session 9 through her association with a rogue satellite, and joins the crew by hacking the Bebop and inviting herself aboard. Watanabe has said that her behaviour was modelled on Yoko Kanno as he observed her when they first met: the crew's principle of play was drawn from the composer of its music.

William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) gave cyberpunk its vocabulary, including the term "console cowboy" for the hacker who jacks into cyberspace. In that lexicon Ed is the only true cowboy aboard: the others are bounty hunters, she is a cowboy of the net. That the series makes its console cowboy a child is a deliberate swerve from Gibson's noir. Case, Gibson's hero, is a burned-out adult whose relation to cyberspace is addiction; Ed's relation to the net is play.

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) argued that the cyborg, the hybrid of organism and machine, is the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, but that illegitimate offspring are often exceedingly unfaithful to their origins. The cyborg, Haraway wrote, has no origin story in the Western sense: no garden, no fall, no mother to return to. Ed is the series' cyborg child in exactly this sense. She was left by her father, names herself, refuses gender as a binary, and treats every system (the satellite, the ship's computer, the bounty databases) as a playground rather than a master. Her origin story, when the series finally supplies it, is a joke about forgetting.

6.2 THE SATELLITE THAT DREW ON THE EARTH

Session 9, "Jamming with Edward," concerns a damaged surveillance satellite whose artificial intelligence, alone in orbit, has begun to carve enormous figures into the surface of Earth with its lasers. The images recall the geoglyphs of the Nazca desert in Peru, made between roughly 500 BCE and 500 CE and legible only from the air. The satellite is lonely; its drawings are an attempt to communicate with something that can see them. Ed, who can, befriends it.

The episode is the series' purest parable of signal and solitude. A machine abandoned in orbit and a child abandoned on a ruined planet find each other through drawings on a wounded sur-

face. The geoglyph, a message legible only from a great height, is the right figure for a series whose characters communicate obliquely, through gestures, music and missed connections. The satellite's drawings are also its art: made by a being with no use for them except to be seen. The series grants them the dignity of art and grants Ed the role of the one who looks.

6.3 PLAY: HUIZINGA, CAILLOIS, SCHILLER

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) defined play as a free activity, standing outside ordinary life, absorbing the player intensely, connected with no material interest, proceeding within its own boundaries of time and space according to fixed rules. Roger Caillois (*Les Jeux et les hommes*, 1958) distinguished four forms: *agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation) and *ilinx* (vertigo, the voluntary disturbance of perception). One may distribute Caillois's forms across the crew. Spike is *agôn*, the duel. Faye is *alea*, the casino. Jet is *mimicry* in its gentlest form, the bonsai that imitates an ancient tree in miniature. Ed is *ilinx*: she spins, tumbles, hangs upside down and lives in a vertigo of delight. The household is a complete ecology of play, and Ed is its free radical.

Friedrich Schiller's *Briefe über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen* (1795) gave play its most exalted philosophical role. In the fifteenth letter, Schiller argued that the play drive (*Spieltrieb*) mediates between the sensuous drive and the formal drive, and that a human being plays only when human in the full sense of the word and is fully human only when at play. Ed is the Bebop's *Spieltrieb*: the principle that reconciles the crew's material hunger with its formal codes by making both into a game. While she is aboard, even a bounty can be play. When she leaves, play leaves with her, and the remaining sessions are without it.

6.4 THE FATHER WHO MAPS CRATERS

Session 24 brings Ed to her father, Appledelhi, a cartographer who travels Earth measuring the impact craters that its continual meteor fall keeps adding to the surface. He is a man so absorbed in mapping a world that will not hold still that he has lost track of his own child, and greets her with cheerful vagueness.

Jorge Luis Borges's one-paragraph fable "Del rigor en la ciencia" (1946) imagines an empire whose cartographers make a map the size of the empire, which later generations abandon to the desert. Jean Baudrillard opened *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) by inverting the fable: in the age of simulation the map precedes the territory. Appledelhi's map does neither. It can never be finished, because the territory is being rewritten by catastrophe faster than it can be surveyed. He is a cartographer of the sublime, recording the wounds of the planet one crater at a time, and his absorption in the wounds of the world has displaced his care for the wound he left in his daughter. The episode is a quiet anatomy of a whole culture's relation to catastrophe: fascinated by the scale of the damage, inattentive to the child.

Ed goes with him anyway. Her choice is not sentimental (the series is clear that he will not be much of a father) but ontological: she chooses an origin over an ensemble, and in doing so she makes visible what the others have not chosen. Ein follows her.

6.5 EIN: THE GAZE OF THE OVERLOOKED

Ein is a Pembroke Welsh Corgi bred in a laboratory with enhanced intelligence (a "data dog"), stolen in Session 2 and adopted by the crew more or less by accident. The series repeatedly shows the audience glimpses of an intelligence the human characters never recognise: Ein operating devices, following conversations, solving problems in silence. The joke is the structure of a theme. The animal knows more than the humans assume, and the humans never ask.

Jacques Derrida, in the lectures published as *L'Animal que donc je suis* (1997; 2006), began from the experience of being seen naked by his cat and argued that philosophy has organised itself around a refusal to be looked at by the animal, collapsing the multiplicity of living beings into a single category, "the animal," defined by what it lacks. Ein is the series' counter-instance: an animal with something in excess, whose gaze sees the crew more completely than they see one another. Jakob von Uexküll's theory of the *Umwelt* (*Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen*, 1934), the perceptual world specific to each species, adds a further dimension: Ein inhabits the Bebop in a world the crew cannot enter. Haraway's *Companion Species Manifesto* (2003) describes dogs and humans as co-constituted through a history of "significant otherness." Ein is significant otherness aboard a ship of people who struggle to recognise the significance of one another.

The name invites one more reading. *Ein* is German for "one," and the dog is the one member of the crew who is never counted. In the household of a man named Mirror, the silent animal named One is the witness who completes the number.

6.6 THE LUDIC REMAINDER AND THE TURN TO REQUIEM

Ed and Ein are the series' remainder: what is left over when the economy of bounties and the tragedy of the past have taken their share. They contribute nothing to the Red Dragon arc; their sessions are the series' most comic and most utopian. This is not an accident of characterisation but a structural function. Play and animality are the forms of existence that the series' syncopic ontology does not touch. Ed has no elided past to mourn (her past is a forgotten father she cheerfully recovers); Ein has an excess rather than a lack. Neither lives in revenant time.

Their departure therefore marks the turn. Session 24 is followed immediately by the two-part "The Real Folk Blues," and the Bebop that enters those sessions is a ship without play. Hannah Arendt located the miracle that saves the world from ruin in natality, the fact that new human beings are born and so new beginnings are possible (*The Human Condition*, 1958). Ed is the Bebop's natality, and the series removes her before the ending so that the ending can be an end-

ing. In the dramaturgy that Chapter 10 reconstructs, her exit is the clearing of the stage before the final dance.



CHAPTER 7

VICIOUS, JULIA AND THE RED DRAGON

Cormorant, Image and Palace

> *His bird is his self-image and his sentence.*

7

7.1 THE STORY BENEATH THE STORIES
7.2 THE CORMORANT AND THE CORMORANT BOAT
7.3 VICIOUS: PUNK, NIHILIST, EGOIST
7.4 MIMETIC DOUBLES: GIRARD
7.5 JULIA: THE IMAGE
7.6 GIRI AND NINJŌ
7.7 THE NINKYŌ WALK
7.8 THE DRAGON PALACE

THE RED DRAGON SYNDICATE is the gravitational system of the series' past: a body so dense that everything Spike does is, in the end, an orbit around it. This chapter reads its three principal elements (Vicious, the rival; Julia, the image; the syndicate itself, the palace) through Japanese, Greek and European instruments, and argues that the series constructs the past not as a memory but as an economy of desire whose master figure is a bird that hunts and cannot swallow.

7.1 THE STORY BENEATH THE STORIES

The series releases the backstory in fragments, and its outline is simple. Spike and Vicious rose together in the Red Dragon under the patronage of Mao Yenrai. They were partners and friends. Spike fell in love with Julia, Vicious's lover, and resolved to leave the syndicate with her. Vicious discovered the affair and ordered Julia to kill Spike at the graveyard where the lovers had agreed to meet, threatening to have them both killed if she refused. Julia, rather than kill or betray him, vanished, and did not keep the rendezvous where Spike waited for her. Spike left the syndicate by staging his death. Vicious fought in the Titan War, returned, and continued to rise. In Session 5 he murders Mao; in Session 25 he attempts a coup against the syndicate's ruling elders, the Van, survives their counter-move (they arrest him and send their own killers after Spike and Julia) when his men turn on the elders, kills them and declares himself leader; in Session 26, syndicate gunmen hunting the pair shoot Annie, who had sheltered Spike, in her store and leave her to die, and on a rooftop one of the gunmen Vicious has sent after them shoots Julia in the back as she and Spike attempt to flee; Spike then walks into the syndicate's headquarters to settle the account.

The plot is a melodrama of the oldest kind. Its interest lies in how the series dresses it: in the iconography of a bird, the economy of an image, and the architecture of a palace.

7.2 THE CORMORANT AND THE CORMORANT BOAT

Vicious is almost always shown with a black cormorant perched on his shoulder. The image has an Anglophone lineage in the shoulder-borne birds of pirate iconography, and fan commentary has proposed a debt to the bird that accompanies Matsumoto Leiji's space pirate Captain Harlock. But in a Japanese work the cormorant carries a far more specific charge, because it is the instrument of *ukai*, cormorant fishing, practised on the Nagara River at Gifu and elsewhere for well over a millennium.

In *ukai*, a cormorant master (*ushō*) fishes at night from a wooden boat (*ubune*), lit by a fire basket hung over the water, controlling a team of cormorants on leashes. A snare is tied at the base of each bird's neck, loose enough to let it breathe and swallow small fish but tight enough to stop it swallowing large ones. The bird dives, catches the sweetfish (*ayu*), and cannot swallow it; the master draws the bird back and takes the fish from its throat. The cormorant is a hunter whose catch belongs to another.

Matsuo Bashō watched the cormorant boats at Gifu in the summer of 1688 and wrote a haiku that has become the emblem of the practice:

omoshirōte
yagate kanashiki
ubune kana

Delightful, and then, soon enough, sorrowful: the cormorant boats. (Author's translation.)

The poem records the spectacle's exhilaration (the fire, the diving birds, the flashing fish) and the melancholy that follows it, a melancholy partly for the birds and partly for the passing of the spectacle itself. It is, word for word, a description of the series' affective arc: delightful, and then, soon enough, sorrowful. The comic sessions are the fire on the water; the final sessions are what remains when the boats have gone.

The cormorant on Vicious's shoulder condenses the series' economy into an emblem. Vicious is a cormorant who wants to be the master. For years he has hunted for the syndicate, catching what he could not keep; his coup is the act of cutting his own snare by killing the elders who held the leash. Yet he still cannot swallow. He cannot possess Julia, who fled him; he cannot consume Spike, who will not stay dead; he cannot hold the syndicate, which he seizes only in the session before his death. His bird is his self-image and his sentence. Chapter 10 extends the emblem to the whole crew, whose ship was literally a fishing boat and whose quarry, almost always, escapes their throats.

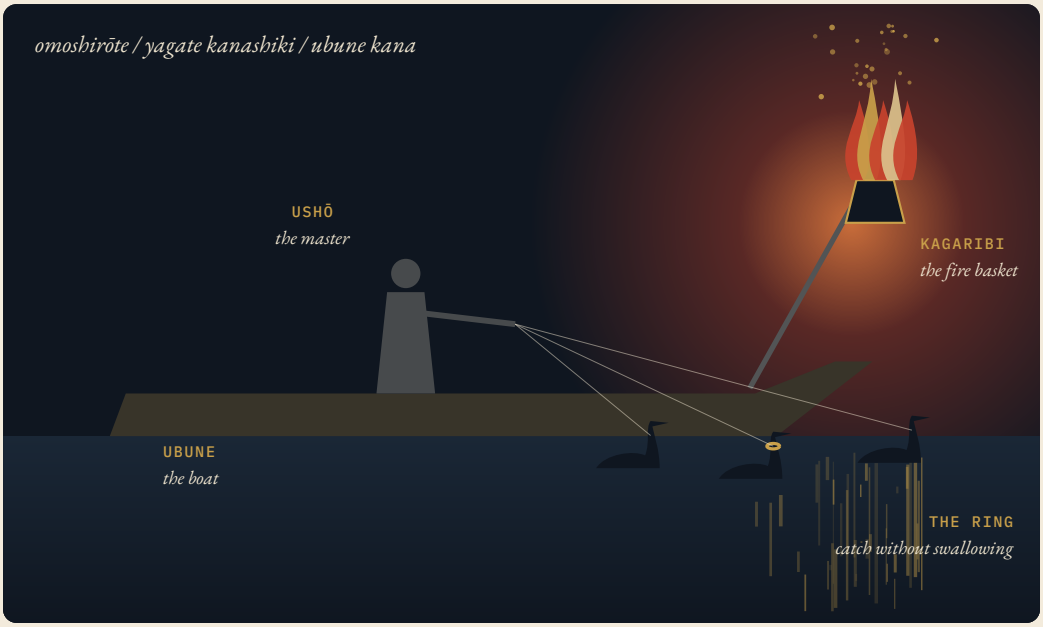


FIG. 5 Ukai: *the ringed cormorant catches what it cannot swallow, after the scene Bashō watched at Gifu in 1688.*

7.3 VICIOUS: PUNK, NIHILIST, EGOIST

The name invites a musical reading that completes the series' jazz grammar. Sid Vicious, bassist of the Sex Pistols, dead of an overdose in 1979, was the iconic figure of British punk, a movement whose aesthetic was negation: three chords, contempt for virtuosity, the declared absence of a future. If Spike is bebop, Vicious is punk. Bebop transforms an inherited form from within; punk tears it down. Bebop phrases freely over the changes; punk refuses the changes. The two men's rivalry is, at this level, a rivalry between two answers to an exhausted tradition, improvisation and negation, and the series' sympathies are clear.

Philosophically, Vicious is an active nihilist in the sense Nietzsche sketched in the notes collected as *Der Wille zur Macht*: a will that has recognised the collapse of all values and turned to destruction, without passing beyond destruction to the creation of new values. He also resembles the egoist of Max Stirner's *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* (1844), which opens by borrowing a line from Goethe's poem "Vanitas! Vanitatum vanitas!": *Ich hab' mein' Sach' auf nichts gestellt*, I have set my cause on nothing. Stirner's unique one recognises no "spook" (no God, nation, humanity, morality or love) with a claim on him. Vicious professes exactly this freedom. When Gren asks him in Session 13 why he had testified against him as a spy after the war, he answers that there is nothing to believe in and no need to believe; he trusts no one and serves nothing. Moments later Lin, the young soldier assigned to him, steps in front of Gren's bullet to save him, and Vicious leaves him where he falls; in Session 26 he warns Lin's brother, Shin, not to follow in Lin's footsteps. His obsession with Spike betrays it. The one thing he cannot set at nothing is the man who left, and the egoist who acknowledges no spook is possessed by a ghost.

Dostoevsky's Stavrogin in *Besy* (*Demons*, 1871–72) is the closest literary relative: a man of overwhelming charisma whose centre is a void, around whom others organise their passions and who can neither love nor believe. The series often associates Vicious with the snake (the Van call him the poisonous snake, and the shaman Laughing Bull gives him the same name), and the association completes the portrait: the tempter of the garden, the creature that sheds its skin, the figure of a cunning that cannot rest.

The oldest Japanese verdict on such ambition opens the *Heike monogatari*: the bell of the Gion temple sounds the impermanence of all things; the proud do not endure, they are like a dream on a spring night; the mighty fall at last, like dust before the wind (author's translation). The *Heike* narrates the destruction of the Taira clan by the Minamoto in the wars of 1180 to 1185, and one of its episodes, in which the Minamoto warrior Kumagai Naozane kills the sixteen-year-old Taira Atsumori at Ichi-no-tani and afterwards renounces the world to become a monk, is the source of the Noh play discussed in Chapter 10. Vicious's reign lasts a night, shorter than a spring night's dream.

7.4 MIMETIC DOUBLES: GIRARD

René Girard's *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961) argued that desire is mimetic: we desire objects because a model desires them, so that desire is triangular (subject, model, object) rather than linear. When model and subject come close, the model becomes a rival, the object recedes in importance, and the rivals come to desire each other's being. In *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) Girard described how mimetic rivalry, spreading through a community, produces a "sacrificial crisis" in which differences collapse and the rivals become "monstrous doubles," until violence is discharged onto a victim.

Spike and Vicious are a textbook case. Trained by the same master, shaped in the same organisation, they desire the same woman and the same freedom. As the series proceeds, Julia recedes behind their rivalry: Vicious's hatred of Spike exceeds any claim to Julia, and Spike's return in the last session is no longer to save her (she is already dead) but to meet Vicious. The final exchange, in which each delivers a mortal wound at almost the same instant, is the resolution Girard's theory predicts when no scapegoat is available: the doubles destroy each other.

The Greek archetype is precise. In Aeschylus's *Seven Against Thebes* (467 BCE), the brothers Eteocles and Polynices, sons of Oedipus, quarrel over the rule of Thebes and kill each other in single combat at the seventh gate. The enemy brothers of the oldest Western tragedy die at a gate; the enemy brothers of a series whose world was broken by a gate die on a staircase. The Japanese tradition supplies its own counterpart in countless tales of sworn brothers turned rivals, and Hong Kong cinema, from Woo's *A Better Tomorrow* to its many heirs, made the betrayed brotherhood the master plot of the triad film.

7.5 JULIA: THE IMAGE

Julia barely exists as a character until the final two sessions. For most of the series she is an image: a blonde woman glimpsed in flashback, a name spoken by others, a face Spike sees with his past eye. She is the purest instance in the series of what Lacan called the object-cause of desire, an absence around which a subject organises himself.

Three mythic patterns inform her. The first is Orpheus and Eurydice, told by Virgil (*Georgics* IV) and Ovid (*Metamorphoses* X): the singer descends to the underworld to retrieve his dead wife and loses her when he looks back. The second is its Japanese counterpart in the *Kojiki* (712): Izanagi descends to the land of the dead, Yomi, to bring back his wife Izanami; she asks him not to look at her; he lights a torch, sees her decaying body, and flees, sealing the passage with a boulder. Both myths turn on a prohibition against looking at the dead. Spike, who sees the past through one eye, has never stopped looking back, and the series' version of the myth grants him the reunion the myths deny and then withdraws it on the rooftop: Julia returns from the underworld of the syndicate and is killed on a rooftop, shot in the back by one of the gunmen Vicious has sent after them.

The third pattern is the *Liebestod*, the love-death of Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865), in which love finds consummation only in death and the lovers die one after the other. Julia's last words, spoken in Spike's arms, return to the master metaphor: it was a dream. The phrase is her *Liebestod*, and Spike's death, which follows within the hour, completes it. One further resonance is worth recording without insisting on it. "Julia" is the title of John Lennon's song for his dead mother on the Beatles' 1968 double album, and the series ends with a closing card that borrows the title of a Beatles song from the medley that closes *Abbey Road*. A series that names its lost woman after a song of mourning ends by naming the burden of mourning after a song of carrying.

Julia's agency deserves recovery from her status as image. Ordered to kill the man she loved, she chose neither obedience nor betrayal but disappearance. Her absence was her act of love: she made herself into an image so that he could live. Simone Weil's notion of decreation (*La Pesanteur et la grâce*, 1947), the voluntary withdrawal of the self so that the other may be, is an unexpected but apt gloss. Julia decreated herself, and the series' tragedy is that her withdrawal, meant to free Spike, bound him instead to the image she left.

7.6 GIRI AND NINJŌ

The central conflict of Japanese dramatic tradition is that between *giri* (obligation, the duties of one's position, debts of honour) and *ninjō* (human feeling, especially love and compassion). Chikamatsu Monzaemon built his domestic tragedies (*sewamono*) for the puppet and kabuki stages on this conflict. In *Sonezaki shinjū* (*The Love Suicides at Sonezaki*, 1703) and *Shinjū ten no Amijima* (*The Love Suicides at Amijima*, 1720), lovers trapped between debts, family duties and their passion choose double suicide (*shinjū*), and the plays' most celebrated passages are the *michiyuki*, the poetic journeys of the lovers to the place of their deaths.

The Red Dragon is a system of *giri* and Julia is Spike's *ninjō*. His planned elopement was the refusal of *giri*; his faked death was its evasion; his return is its settlement. The deaths of Julia and Spike, separated in space but joined within a single night, form a *shinjū* in two movements, and Spike's last ascent and descent of the syndicate's stairs is a solitary *michiyuki*, the lover's journey to death undertaken after the beloved has already gone ahead.

7.7 THE NINKYŌ WALK

The Toei studio's *ninkyō eiga* (chivalry films) of the 1960s and early 1970s, especially the series starring Takakura Ken (*Abashiri bangaichi* from 1965; *Shōwa zankyōden* from 1965 to 1972), codified a climax that the series' final session reproduces with uncanny fidelity. The hero, a yakuza of the old code, endures insult and loss inflicted by a corrupt rival gang until he can endure no more; he then walks, often at night and often in snow, to the rival's headquarters for a final, near-suicidal raid (*nagurikomi*). In the *Shōwa zankyōden* films he frequently walks it beside a companion played by Ikebe Ryō, the two men side by side in silence while the theme song plays.

Spike's last approach to the Red Dragon tower, with Shin, Lin's brother, who had first sided with Vicious's coup and then turned to help Spike, beside him, is the *ninkyō* walk. Shin is shot by syndicate soldiers on the way in and dies before Spike reaches Vicious, as the companion so often falls before the last confrontation in the Toei films. Fukasaku Kinji's *Jingi naki tatakai* (*Battles Without Honor and Humanity*, 1973) and its *jitsuroku* ("true record") successors deconstructed the *ninkyō* code by showing the yakuza world as betrayal all the way down. The series sets a *ninkyō* hero inside a *jitsuroku* world: the syndicate Spike walks into has no honour left, its elders plotting, its heir murdering them, its soldiers changing sides. His chivalry has nothing to honour but itself. That is why the walk is not heroic in the old sense but stylistic, a form kept for its own sake. Kitano Takeshi's *Sonatine* (1993), in which bored gangsters play on a beach before the killing resumes and the hero ends his own life, is the contemporary film nearest to the series in tone: play and death in the same frame, neither ironising the other.

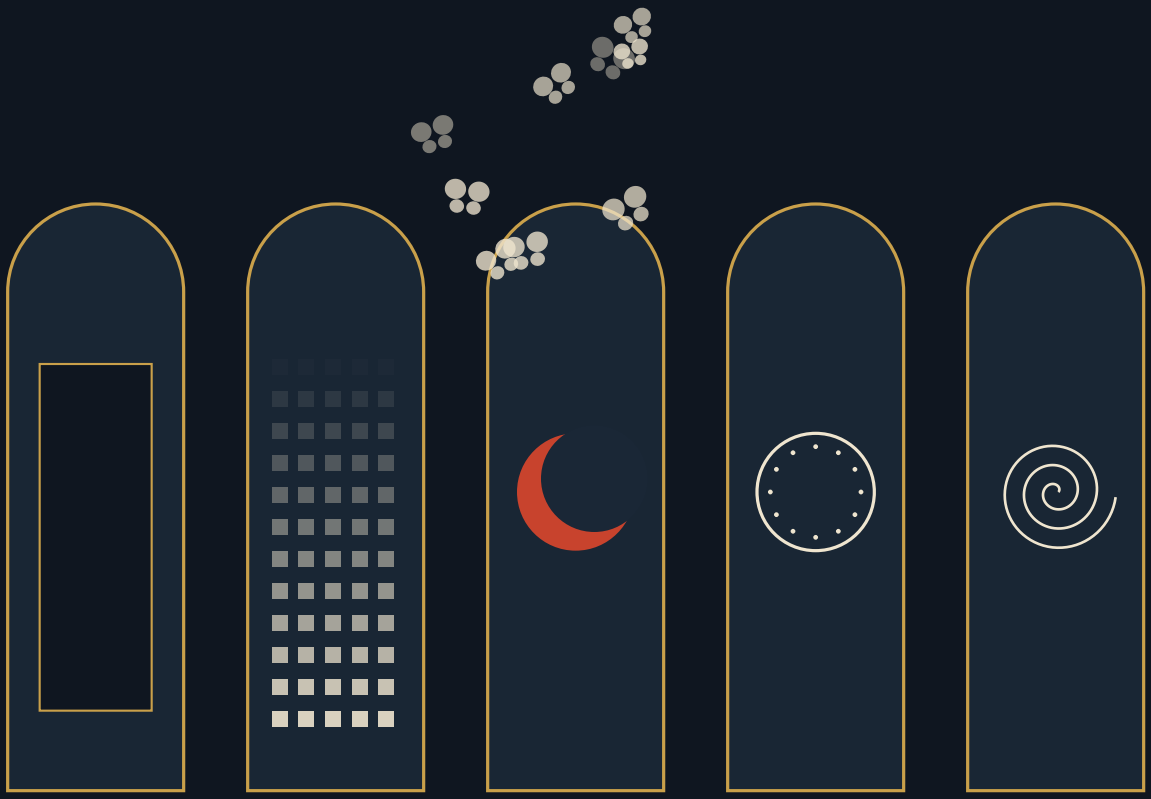
7.8 THE DRAGON PALACE

The dragon of Chinese cosmology (*lóng*) is a figure of imperial power and of water, and the dragon kings of the four seas rule palaces beneath the waves. Japanese tradition absorbed them in the *Ryūgū-jō*, the undersea palace of the Urashima tale, where time runs differently and the visitor forgets the world above. The Red Dragon is the series' *Ryūgū*. It is the palace of Spike's youth, where time was arrested in an image of a woman and a brotherhood; to return to it is to open the box. The syndicate's elders, the Van, figure as its dragon kings, aged and ceremonial, and their murder by Vicious is the palace turning on itself.

Gren completes the system from the outside. A veteran of the Titan War who served beside Vicious, he was imprisoned after the war as a suspected spy on Vicious's testimony; in prison, by his own account, he was made a test subject in drug trials, and the medication disrupted his hormones and gave his body female secondary sex characteristics. Julia had spent a month on Callisto in 2069 and come to know him, which is why her name can serve as the lure. In Sessions 12 and 13 he tells Faye the story of the war and of Vicious, and, mortally wounded when Vicious fires on his ship, he asks to be sent towards Titan; Spike carries him into his ship and launches him on his last flight. Gren is the witness who narrates the palace from outside its walls. Chapter 10 will argue that his role is formally that of the narrator who, in the middle of a ghost play, tells the backstory in plain speech while the ghost is off stage.

The treatment of Gren has to be described as exactly as the rest. The changes to his body were done to him, by prison authorities who used prisoners as test subjects, after an imprisonment procured by a comrade's testimony. The end of Session 12 stages the discovery of his body as a spectacle: the critic Allyson Johnson has faulted the direction for eroticising it and for Faye's question about which sex he is, and has noted that earlier in the same two-parter a transgender character, Julius, is made the butt of a joke (*The Mary Sue*, 2015. The episodes then give Gren a dignity they withhold from Julius: he is a musician, a witness and a mourner, and his death is the

series' most tender. An earlier draft of this study called Gren a figure of the between. The phrase needs correcting. His betweenness is not an emblem he chose but an injury inflicted on him, and the series' sympathy for him does not undo its joke at Julius's expense. If Gren belongs in the syncopic ontology, it is as its starkest reminder that elision is often something one person does to another.



PART THREE · COUNTER-MODELS AND CONSTELLATIONS

CHAPTER 8

FALSE EXITS

Sovereignty, Upload, Apocalypse

> *Each is a refusal of syncope, and each is, in the series' judgement, a form of death disguised as liberation.*

8

8.1 A TYPOLOGY OF ESCAPE
8.2 SOVEREIGNTY: VICIOUS
8.3 UPLOAD: BRAIN SCRATCH
8.4 APOCALYPSE: KNOCKIN' ON HEAVEN'S DOOR
8.5 ARREST AND REGRESSION: WEN AND MAD PIERROT
8.6 WHAT THE FALSE EXITS SHARE

A PHILOSOPHY IS TESTED by what it refuses. The series stages, across its sessions and its film, a set of figures who attempt to escape the syncopic condition (to live without the elided beat, the displaced accent and the swoon) by abolishing the structure that produces it. This chapter reads three principal false exits (sovereign nihilism, digital transcendence and apocalyptic oblivion) and two subsidiary ones (arrested time and regression), and argues that what unites them is an attempt to abolish the interval rather than to inhabit it.

8.1 A TYPOLOGY OF ESCAPE

If the syncopic subject lives on the weak beat of a history whose strong beat has already fallen, there are, schematically, five ways to try to leave. One may seize the downbeat, making oneself the source of the metre (sovereignty). One may leave the body, and with it the rhythm that binds the body to time (upload). One may end the music altogether, so that no beat is strong or weak (apocalypse). One may stop the clock, refusing the passage of bars (arrest). Or one may regress below the threshold at which metre is felt, into an infantile present without phrases (regression). The series assigns each exit to a figure, and each figure dies.

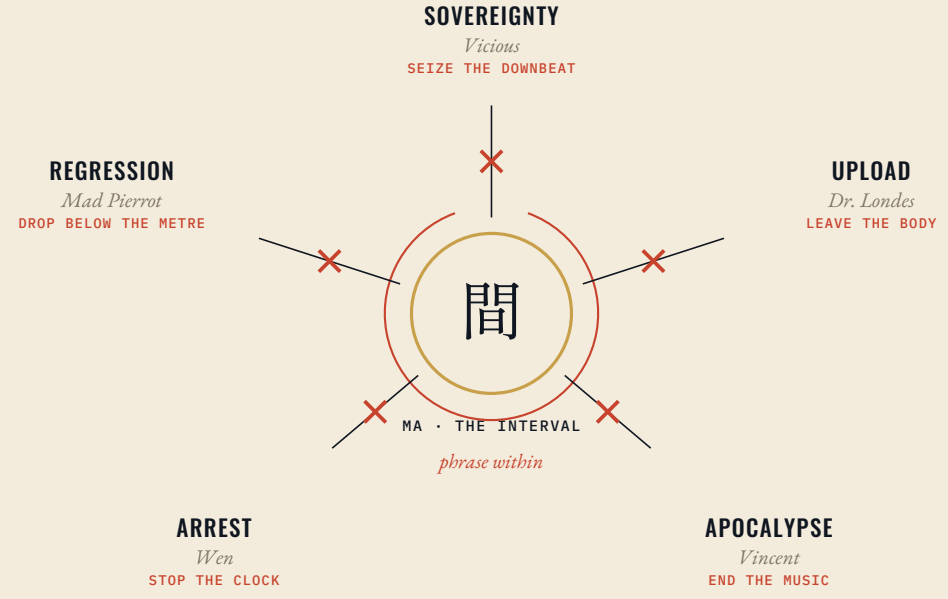


FIG. 6 *Five false exits from the interval, each a death disguised as liberation.*

8.2 SOVEREIGNTY: VICIOUS

Carl Schmitt opened *Politische Theologie* (1922) by defining the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. Vicious's coup in Session 25 is a Schmittian act: he suspends the syndicate's order, decides who lives and who dies, and installs himself as its source. In musical terms he attempts to seize the downbeat, to become the one who sets the time rather than the one who phrases within it.

The definition has a history that its use here must carry. Schmitt joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933. In 1934 he published "Der Führer schützt das Recht" ("The Leader Protects the Law"), defending as lawful the killings of the Night of the Long Knives, in which, on Hitler's orders, the leadership of the SA and other political opponents were murdered without trial; in 1936 he organised a conference directed against what it called Jewish influence on German legal science. For its theorist, the sovereign decision was the legal form of a dictatorship. The series stages that sovereignty in a criminal syndicate and gives it a single night.

Georges Bataille offered a different concept of sovereignty in the unfinished *La Souveraineté* (written 1953–56): the sovereign moment is not mastery but useless expenditure, a moment that serves nothing and is valued for itself, like laughter, eroticism, sacrifice or the swoon. Bataille's sovereignty is, in the terms of this study, syncopic: it is the moment that falls out of the economy of means and ends. Vicious confuses the two sovereignties. He wants Bataille's freedom and pursues it by Schmitt's means, and the result is the cormorant's fate described in Chapter 7. He cuts the leash and still cannot swallow; he holds the syndicate for a night and dies on its stairs. Spike, by contrast, achieves something closer to Bataille's sovereignty in his last walk: an act that serves no end, gains nothing and is undertaken for its own sake.

8.3 UPLOAD: BRAIN SCRATCH

Session 23, "Brain Scratch," concerns a cult called SCRATCH whose televised guru, Dr. Londes, promises followers liberation from the body through the transfer of the mind into the network. Followers vanish into comas. Faye infiltrates the cult, Ed investigates its signal, and the crew discovers that Londes is a virtual persona projected by Ronny Spangen, a boy who lies in a vegetative state in a hospital, his consciousness active only in the net. The session ends on a television being switched off.

The episode is the series' most direct engagement with the transhumanist imaginary of its decade. Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988) had popularised the idea of uploading the mind into machines; Ray Kurzweil's *The Age of Spiritual Machines* (1999) would soon give it a millenarian frame. The episode also has precise historical coordinates. In March 1997, thirty-nine members of the American group Heaven's Gate, including its leader, Marshall Applewhite, took their lives at the group's house in Rancho Santa Fe, California (the group supported itself partly by designing websites), in the belief that they would leave their bodily "vehicles" and ascend to a

spacecraft trailing the comet Hale–Bopp. Two years earlier, Aum Shinrikyō's sarin attack on the Tokyo subway, ordered by its founder Asahara Shōkō, had shown Japan what an apocalyptic sect of educated young people could do. SCRATCH is both: a media cult of disembodied ascent.

The philosophical lineage of the upload is older than its technology. Plato's *Phaedo* presents philosophy as the practice of dying, the soul's rehearsal of its release from the body's prison; ancient Gnosticism made the body a cage from which the spark of spirit must escape. The series refuses the lineage. It reveals the guru of disembodiment to be a disabled child dreaming in a hospital bed: transcendence turns out to be the fantasy of a body that has failed, broadcast to bodies that have not. The refusal places the series against two of its most celebrated contemporaries. Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) ends with its heroine merging with an artificial intelligence and entering the net as a new form of life, a conclusion the film presents as transcendence. *Serial Experiments Lain* (1998), broadcast in the same year as *Cowboy Bebop*, ends with its heroine dissolving into the network as a kind of god who erases herself from memory. *Cowboy Bebop* takes the opposite side. Its bodies are prosthetic, damaged, hungry and mortal, but they are the only sites of existence it recognises. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology of the lived body (*Phénoménologie de la perception*, 1945), for which consciousness is first of all a bodily being-in-the-world, is the implicit philosophy of the episode's last image. The switched-off screen returns the viewer to the room.

The episode also answers the media theory of its century. Marshall McLuhan argued that the medium is the message (*Understanding Media*, 1964); Guy Debord, that modern life had become an accumulation of spectacles (*La Société du spectacle*, 1967); Baudrillard, that simulation had replaced the real. David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983) dramatised a television signal that rewrites the flesh of its viewers. "Brain Scratch" accepts the diagnosis and refuses the conclusion. The screen can capture minds, but what it offers is not transcendence; it is a coma.

8.4 APOCALYPSE: KNOCKIN' ON HEAVEN'S DOOR

The film's antagonist, Vincent Volaju, is a former soldier of a Martian special-forces unit, a veteran of the Titan War, and the only survivor of a military experiment with nanomachines that destroyed his memory and his capacity to distinguish dream from waking. He sees butterflies. He plans to release a nanomachine pathogen over Mars on Halloween, killing its population, in order to end what he experiences as an intolerable dream. He is hunted by Spike, whom he defeats once and who returns to fight him on a tower above the city, and by Electra Ovilo, a former lover from the same unit, sent by Cherious Medical, the pharmaceutical company that illegally manufactured the nanomachine weapon for the Martian military and now wants the matter buried. As Vincent prepares to kill Spike, Electra shoots him, and he dies remembering their time together.

The butterflies are an explicit citation. In the second chapter of the *Zhuangzi* (*Qiwu lun*, "On the Equality of Things"), Zhuang Zhou dreams he is a butterfly, fluttering happily and unaware of being Zhou; waking, he cannot tell whether he is Zhou who dreamt of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming that it is Zhou. The passage concludes that between Zhou and the butterfly there must be a distinction, and that this is what is called the transformation of things (*wuhua*). For Zhuangzi, the uncertainty is liberating: it loosens the grip of a fixed self and opens the sage to the ceaseless transformations of the world. For Vincent, the same uncertainty is torment, and he resolves it by violence. If he cannot tell dream from waking, he will end both for everyone. His apocalypse is the Zhuangzian insight inverted into a death sentence.

The film's Japanese title, *Tengoku no tobira* ("Heaven's Door"), and its English title, borrowed from the song Bob Dylan wrote for Peckinpah's *Pat Garrett and Billy the Kid* (1973), frame the apocalypse as a threshold. The song belongs to a dying lawman; the film's Halloween is the festival at which the boundary between the living and the dead is thinnest. Vincent wants to throw the door open for everyone at once. Pedro Calderón de la Barca's *La vida es sueño* (1635) offers the counter-position the series adopts. Its prince Segismundo, imprisoned, released, re-imprisoned and persuaded that his freedom was a dream, concludes that since life may be a dream one must nonetheless act well, because good deeds are not lost even in dreams. Spike's ethic is Segismundo's: the dream does not excuse; one must still play well inside it. Spike tells Faye he has been watching a dream; he does not conclude, as Vincent does, that the dream should be ended for others.

8.5 ARREST AND REGRESSION: WEN AND MAD PIERROT

Two subsidiary exits complete the typology. In Session 6, "Sympathy for the Devil," the crew pursues Wen, who appears to be a child playing the harmonica but is in fact decades old: an exposure to the Gate Accident stopped his body's aging. Wen is cruel, weary and eager to die; his immortality is a prison. Spike ends him with a shot that releases, at once, the years his body had withheld, and he ages into an old man as he dies. Wen is the figure of arrested time, kin to J. M. Barrie's Peter Pan (1904) and to the immortals of the Western imagination who wished they could die, from Tithonus, granted endless life without endless youth, to Jonathan Swift's struldbrugs (*Gulliver's Travels*, 1726). The episode answers Jet's stopped watch from the other side: arrested time is not a refuge from death but a form of it.

In Session 20, "Pierrot le Fou," Spike is hunted by Mad Pierrot, an assassin whose body was augmented in military experiments and whose mind was reduced to an infant's. He kills with delight, cries when hurt, and corners Spike in a deserted amusement park, where he is finally crushed beneath a marching parade of mechanical toys. The title cites Jean-Luc Godard's *Pierrot le fou* (1965), whose fugitive hero, having fled Paris with his lover, paints his face blue and blows himself up. The figure behind both is Pierrot of the *commedia dell'arte* and the French pantomime, the white-faced, moonstruck clown whom Albert Giraud's *Pierrot lunaire* (1884) and

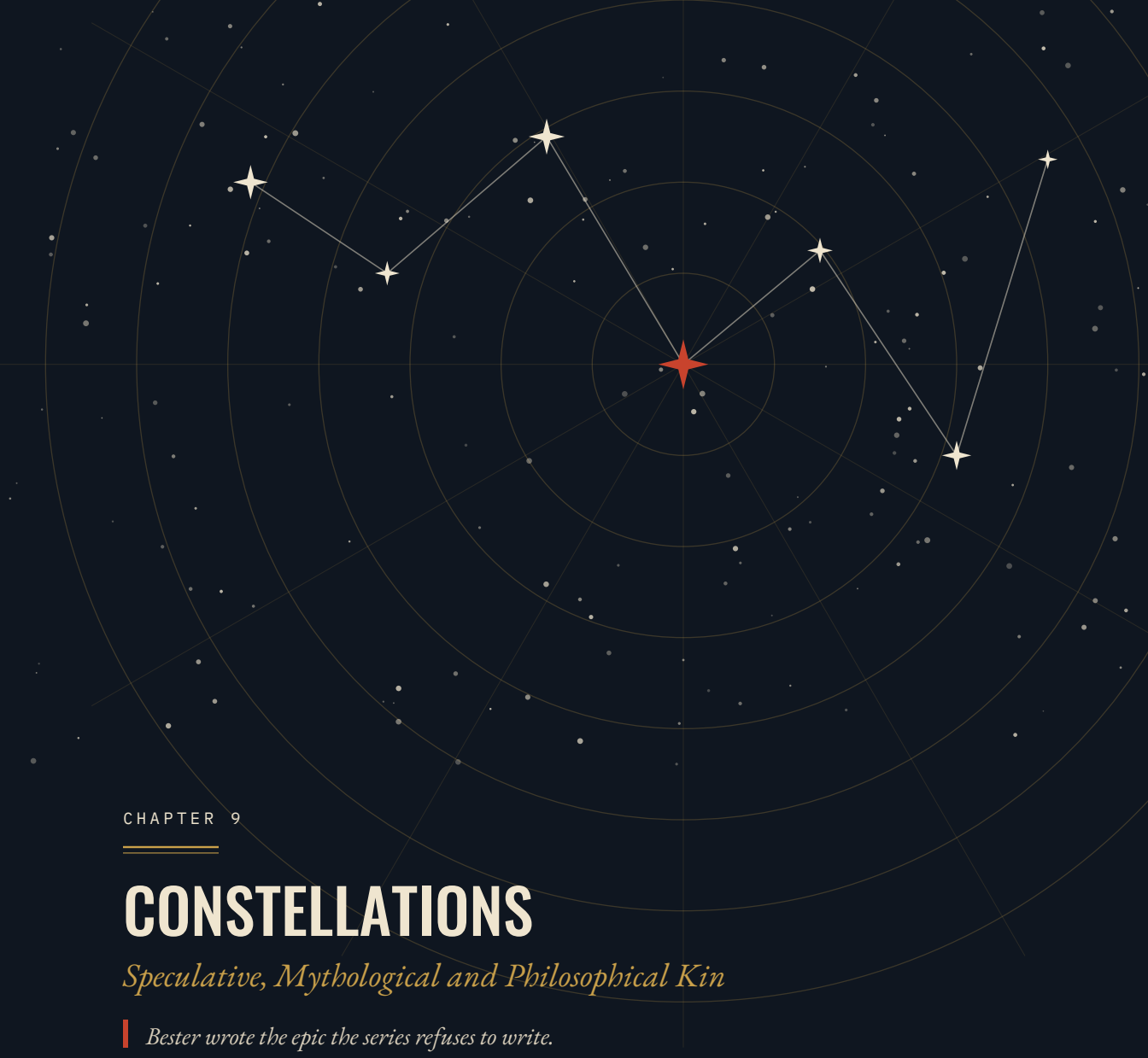
Arnold Schoenberg's setting (1912) made the emblem of modern alienation. A moonstruck clown in a world with a shattered moon: the episode's icon is exact.

Mad Pierrot is the obscene double of Ed. Both are children of the network and of experiment, and both inhabit *ilinx*, the vertigo of play. But Ed's play includes others and Pierrot's abolishes them. His regression below the level of the phrase, into a present of pure impulse without memory or anticipation, is the false exit of play without an ensemble. That he is destroyed by toys in a theme park dedicated to a commodified future is the series' bleakest joke about where infantile play leads when it is taken over by power.

8.6 WHAT THE FALSE EXITS SHARE

The five exits differ in content but share a form. Each attempts to abolish the interval rather than inhabit it. Sovereignty abolishes it by seizing the strong beat. Upload abolishes it by escaping the body in which beats are felt. Apocalypse abolishes it by ending the music. Arrest abolishes it by stopping the clock. Regression abolishes it by dropping below the threshold of metre. Each is a refusal of syncope, and each is, in the series' judgement, a form of death disguised as liberation.

The series' own answer, developed in Chapter 10, is the opposite: to stay in the interval and phrase within it, to accept the elided beat, the displaced accent and the swoon as the conditions of a freedom that is real because it is limited. Spike also dies, of course. The difference between his death and the deaths of Vicious, Londes, Vincent, Wen and Pierrot is the difference between a phrase that is completed and a piece that is destroyed.



CHAPTER 9

CONSTELLATIONS

Speculative, Mythological and Philosophical Kin

> *Bester wrote the epic the series refuses to write.*

9.1 SPECULATIVE FICTION: THE IMAGE, THE OCEAN AND THE HALF-LIFE
9.2 MYTH: DESCENTS, SLEEPERS, GHOST SHIPS AND HUNTERS
9.3 PHILOSOPHICAL FICTION: THE RECORD, THE INSTANT, THE DOOR
9.4 SUMMARY OF THE CONSTELLATION

9

THIS CHAPTER BUILDS THE comparative constellation the method requires. It does not catalogue influences but arranges elective affinities (in the sense Goethe borrowed from chemistry for *Die Wahlverwandtschaften*, 1809) so that each work illuminates a facet of the series that the others leave dark. It proceeds through three fields (speculative fiction, myth and philosophical fiction) and closes with a summary table.

9.1 SPECULATIVE FICTION: THE IMAGE, THE OCEAN AND THE HALF-LIFE

Chris Marker, *La Jetée* (1962). Marker's photo-roman, composed almost entirely of still images, follows a man selected by the survivors of a nuclear war for experiments in time travel because he is obsessed with an image from his childhood: a woman's face on the observation pier at Orly, and a man falling. He is sent into the past, finds the woman, loves her, and finally runs towards her on the same pier, where he is shot and understands that the death he witnessed as a child was his own. No work is closer to Spike's structure: an image of a woman preserved from before a catastrophe, a return to the past that is also a return to one's death, and a final run towards the beloved that completes a memory by ending its rememberer. Marker's film is built of stills with a single moving shot (the woman opening her eyes); the series, an art of limited animation, is likewise built from held images, and its most moving shots are often its stillest. Alfred Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958), whose hero falls in love with a woman who seems to be possessed by the dead and loses her twice from a tower, is the film behind *La Jetée* (Marker returned to it in *Sans soleil*, 1983) and behind Spike's fall in the cathedral.

Stanisław Lem, *Solaris* (1961), and Andrei Tarkovsky, *Solyaris* (1972). Lem's sentient ocean materialises the dead wife of the psychologist Kelvin from his memory, a being who is and is not her and who comes to suffer her own derivative existence. Tarkovsky's adaptation ends with Kelvin kneeling before his father at the family dacha, and the camera pulls back to reveal the house as an island formed by the ocean: the homecoming is a materialised memory. The image is Faye's Session 24 in reverse. Kelvin returns to a home that the alien ocean has reconstructed from memory; Faye returns to a home that the meteor fall has reduced to foundations. Both films ask what it means to be given back the past as an object, and both answer that the past so given cannot be lived in. Tarkovsky's theory of cinema as "sculpting in time" (*Zapechatlennoe vremya*, published in English as *Sculpting in Time*, 1986), with its attention to the pressure of time within the shot, is the most useful film theory for the series' long held images.

Philip K. Dick. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) gave science fiction its archetypal bounty hunter, Rick Deckard, who "retires" escaped androids for bounties and comes to suspect that his quarry is more capable of feeling than he is. Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) transposed the novel into the rain-soaked, neon-lit, Asian-inflected megalopolis that the series' Mars inherits; its engineered soldiers who want more life than their makers allowed are ancestors of Mad Pierrot and Vincent. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) supplies a more surprising key. Its dead are not quite dead: they are kept in "cold-pac" in moratoriums, conscious in a fading "half-life"

through which the living can consult them. Faye was literally cold-packed; Spike lives his whole life in a half-life after his staged death. *Ubik* is the speculative-fiction name for revenant time.

Alfred Bester, *The Stars My Destination* (1956). Bester's Gully Foyle, left to die in a wrecked ship by a passing vessel that refuses to rescue him, transforms himself into an instrument of revenge in a solar system reshaped by "jaunting," the human capacity to teleport. The novel rewrites Dumas's *Le Comte de Monte-Cristo* (1844–46) for the space age, and its climax dissolves into typographical synaesthesia as Foyle experiences time and space all at once. Its points of contact are the transformative technology that reorganises society (jaunting, the Gates), the protagonist bound to a single past injury, and the vision of himself across time that Foyle encounters as the "Burning Man." Its divergence is instructive. Foyle's revenge becomes enlightenment and he offers humanity the stars; Spike's reckoning ends on a staircase. Bester wrote the epic the series refuses to write.

Ursula K. Le Guin, *The Dispossessed* (1974). Le Guin's physicist Shevek labours to unify two theories of time, Sequency (time as an arrow) and Simultaneity (time as a whole present at once), in a General Temporal Theory. Spike's two eyes are Sequency and Simultaneity unreconciled: one sees the present moving forward, the other sees the past present all at once. Shevek unifies them in theory and returns home; Spike unifies them only in the moment of his death. Le Guin's novel also offers, in its anarchist moon Anarres, the utopia of a voluntary association without property, which the Bebop approximates in miniature and without ideology: a ship where no one is paid, no one commands and no one is obliged to stay.

Japanese space opera and Watanabe–Nobumoto. The series' most direct generic ancestors are Japanese. Matsumoto Leiji's *Uchū kaizoku Kyaputen Hārokku* (*Space Pirate Captain Harlock*, manga 1977–79; anime 1978–79) supplied the melancholy space outlaw with a code; his *Ginga tetsudō Surī Nīn* (*Galaxy Express 999*, 1977–81) supplied the episodic structure of stops on different worlds, each an allegory, and a thesis the series inherits: the boy Tetsurō, who travels the galaxy seeking an immortal machine body, comes to reject it and affirm mortal flesh. Monkey Punch's *Lupin III* (manga from 1967; anime from 1971) supplied the ensemble of rogues, one of whom, Fujiko, is the plain ancestor of Faye. 1998 was the year of the space Western in Japanese television: *Outlaw Star* and *Trigun* aired alongside *Cowboy Bebop*. Within its creators' own work, *Macross Plus* (1994), co-directed by Watanabe with Kawamori Shōji and written by Nobumoto, is the rehearsal: two rival pilots, once friends, bound in mimetic rivalry over a woman with a hidden past, who reconcile at the end. *Cowboy Bebop* rewrites the triangle without reconciliation. Nobumoto's *Wolf's Rain* (2003), in which wolves seek a lost paradise across a dying world and all perish before a new cycle begins, and *Tokyo Godfathers* (2003, with Kon Satoshi), in which three homeless people form a family over one Christmas, show that the two great themes of her Bebop work (the search for an impossible home and the found family that forms on the way) were her own. Watanabe's *Samurai Champloo* (2004), *Sakamichi no Apollon* (*Kids on the Slope*, 2012) and *Carole & Tuesday* (2019) show his continuing method: history scored by a music that arrived later, the contrafact turned into a historiography.

Murakami Haruki. The novelist who ran a Tokyo jazz bar, Peter Cat, from 1974 to 1981 made the drifting, jazz-literate man whose woman has disappeared the protagonist of an era. In *Sekai no owari to hādo boirudo wandārando* (*Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World*, 1985), a man discovers that his consciousness will be sealed permanently inside an inner world, a dream from which he will not wake, and chooses to remain there. In *Nejimaki-dori kuronikuru* (*The Wind-Up Bird Chronicle*, 1994–95), a passive man whose wife has vanished descends into a dry well to reach her in a dark otherworld. Murakami's men accept the dream; Spike leaves it. The kinship and the divergence together locate the series in its national literature.

9.2 MYTH: DESCENTS, SLEEPERS, GHOST SHIPS AND HUNTERS

Chapters 5 and 7 have already placed Faye in the Urashima cycle and Spike in the descents of Orpheus and Izanagi. Four further mythic patterns complete the constellation.

The Flying Dutchman. The legend of a captain condemned to sail forever without reaching port, given operatic form by Wagner in *Der fliegende Holländer* (1843) after a version in Heinrich Heine's *Aus den Memoiren des Herren von Schnabelewopski* (1834), allows the Dutchman ashore once every seven years to seek a woman whose faithfulness unto death will redeem him. Senta casts herself into the sea, the ghost ship sinks, and the two are transfigured. The Bebop is a Flying Dutchman of the solar system: a ship crewed by the not-quite-living that cannot make port, from which its captain's partner is released only when the woman who loved him dies.

Tantalus. Popular readings make Spike a Sisyphus, but the crew's collective figure is Tantalus, whom the *Odyssey* (book 11) shows standing in a pool beneath fruit trees in Hades, the water receding whenever he stoops to drink and the branches lifting whenever he reaches to eat. The bounty hunters are Tantalus with a ship: their catch is always within reach and never in their mouths. Tantalus and the ringed cormorant of Chapter 7 are the Greek and Japanese faces of one condition.

The Wild Hunt. Jacob Grimm's *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835) collected the northern European legend of the Wild Hunt, a host of spectral hunters riding across the sky in pursuit of a quarry they never catch. The American West made its own version in Stan Jones's 1948 cowboy ballad "(Ghost) Riders in the Sky," in which a cowboy sees damned riders driving the devil's herd across the clouds forever, a vision meant as a warning. The space cowboy is a ghost rider: a hunter in the sky whose pursuit is eternal because it is never consummated.

The cat that lived a million times. In the final session Spike recounts the story of Sano Yōko's picture book *Hyakuman-kai ikita neko* (1977), translated as *The Cat That Lived a Million Times*. A tabby cat lives a million lives with a million owners, a king, a sailor, a thief, a little girl, and dies each time without grief, because he loves none of them, and is reborn. At last he is a stray belonging to no one, falls in love with a white cat, raises a family with her, and when she dies he weeps a million times and dies beside her, and is never born again. The fable is the series' one explicit myth, and it is a Buddhist myth turned inside out. In Buddhist doctrine craving and

attachment bind beings to rebirth, and liberation comes through non-attachment. In Sano's fable, a life without attachment is the condition of endless rebirth, and liberation comes through love and the grief that completes it. Chapter 10 builds on this inversion its account of the series' ending as a heterodox release.

9.3 PHILOSOPHICAL FICTION: THE RECORD, THE INSTANT, THE DOOR

Jean-Paul Sartre, *La Nausée* (1938). Sartre's Roquentin, sickened by the contingency of existence, finds a single reprieve: a ragtime record, "Some of These Days," whose melody seems to him to possess a kind of necessity that existence lacks. The novel ends with his resolve to write something that could do for him what the song does, justify an existence by shaping it. *Cowboy Bebop* is a philosophical fiction built on Roquentin's insight: its characters are contingent and superfluous, and their lives acquire whatever necessity they have from the music that shapes them into sessions.

Søren Kierkegaard, *Enten–Eller* (*Either/Or*, 1843). Among the papers of its aesthete is a discourse on "the unhappiest one" (*Den Ulykkeligste*), which defines the unhappy person as one who is always absent from himself, living in hope or in recollection, and the unhappiest as one in whom the two are confounded: he hopes for what lies behind him and recollects what lies ahead. The definition is a portrait of Spike. He hopes for the past (Julia, the interrupted flight); he recollects the future (his death, already performed). Kierkegaard's aesthete offers the unhappiest one no cure. The series offers one, but only at the price of the moment that closes the account.

Jorge Luis Borges, "El milagro secreto" (1943), and Ambrose Bierce, "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890). Borges's playwright Jaromir Hladik, facing a Nazi firing squad, is granted by God a year of subjective time in the instant before the bullets arrive, and completes his play in his mind before he dies. Bierce's condemned man escapes the noose, flees home through a dreamlike landscape and is about to embrace his wife when the narrative snaps back to the bridge: the escape occurred in the instant of the hanging. Both tales offer a hermeneutic temptation that the series' audiences have felt, the suspicion that everything after Spike's fall in the cathedral is an instant of dying expanded into a life. The series neither confirms nor refutes the suspicion; it absorbs it into its master metaphor, the dream that has already ended. It also reverses Borges in its last gesture: instead of time expanding inside a bullet that is coming, Spike fires an imaginary bullet himself, and time ends.

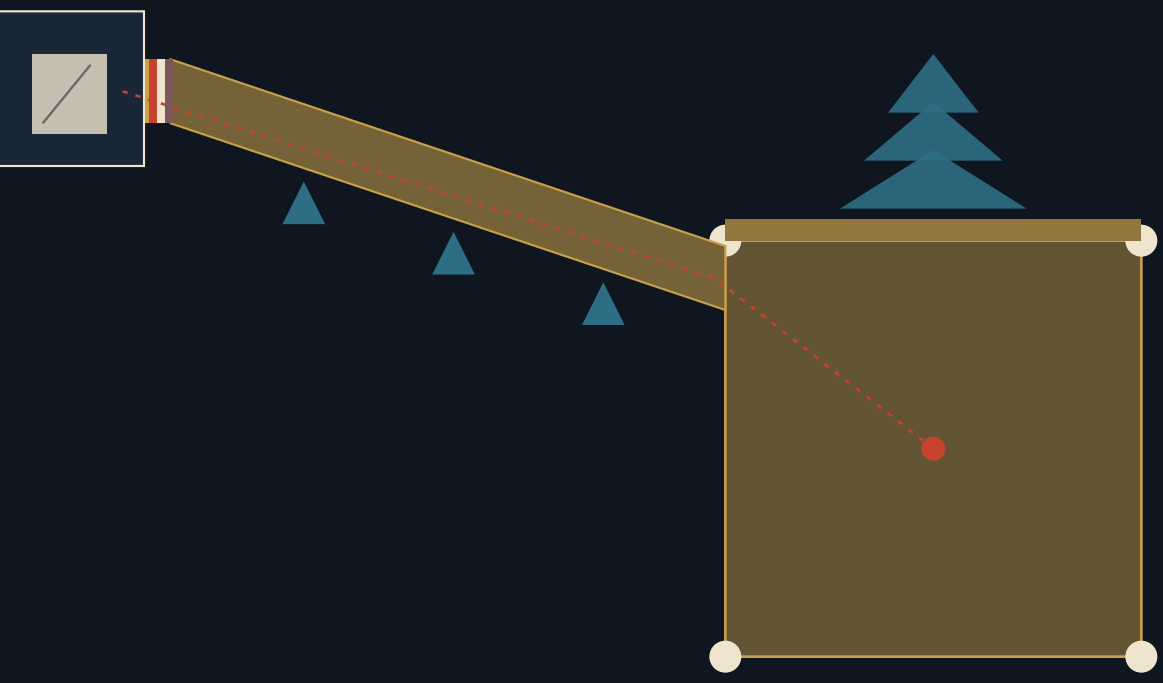
Franz Kafka, "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915). A man from the country waits all his life before the open door of the Law, forbidden by a doorkeeper to enter; dying, he asks why no one else has come in all those years, and is told that this door was meant only for him, and that now it will be shut. The series is full of doors and gates (the hyperspace Gates, the door of heaven in the film's title, the seventh gate at which the enemy brothers of Thebes die). Kafka's parable names what the final session dramatises: Spike's door was meant only for him, and the series ends at the moment he goes through it rather than waiting before it.



FIG. 7 *A constellation in Benjamin's sense: the works read beside the series, by field. Distance from the centre is not rank; the size of a star marks how much of the argument it carries.*

9.4 SUMMARY OF THE CONSTELLATION

WORK	FIELD	POINT OF CONTACT WITH THE SERIES	POINT OF DIVERGENCE
Marker, *La Jetée* (1962)	*Speculative film*	An image of a woman from before catastrophe; return as death	Marker's hero discovers his death; Spike chooses his
Lem / Tarkovsky, *Solaris* (1961 / 1972)	*Speculative fiction and film*	The past returned as object; impossible homecoming	Kelvin accepts the simulacrum; Faye accepts the ensemble
Dick, *Do Androids Dream...?* (1968); *Ubik* (1969)	*Speculative fiction*	The bounty hunter; half-life of the not-quite-dead	Deckard doubts his humanity; Spike doubts his aliveness
Bester, *The Stars My Destination* (1956)	*Speculative fiction*	Revenge in a solar system reshaped by a technology	Foyle's revenge becomes enlightenment; Spike's becomes a cadence
Le Guin, *The Dispossessed* (1974)	*Speculative fiction*	Two theories of time; a voluntary association	Shevek unifies time in theory; Spike only in dying
Matsumoto, *Galaxy Express 999* (1977–81)	*Anime and manga*	Episodic stops; rejection of the immortal machine body	Tetsurō continues; the Bebop disperses
Watanabe and Nobumoto, *Macross Plus* (1994)	*Anime*	Rival friends and a woman with a past	Rivals reconcile; here they destroy each other
Murakami, *Hard-Boiled Wonderland* (1985)	*Fiction*	A consciousness sealed in a dream	Murakami's hero stays; Spike wakes
Wagner, *Der fliegende Holländer* (1843)	*Myth and opera*	Ghost ship released by a woman's death	Senta chooses death; Julia is killed
Sano, *The Cat That Lived a Million Times* (1977)	*Fable*	Release from repetition through love and grief	Told by Spike as his own key
Sartre, *La Nausée* (1938)	*Philosophical fiction*	Music as justification of contingent existence	Roquentin plans to write; the crew plays
Kierkegaard, *Either/Or* (1843)	*Philosophical fiction*	"The unhappiest one" hopes backward and recollects forward	Kierkegaard offers no cure; the series offers the moment
Borges, "The Secret Miracle" (1943)	*Philosophical fiction*	Time expanded in the instant of death	Spike fires the bullet himself
Kafka, "Before the Law" (1915)	*Philosophical fiction*	A door meant only for one man	Spike goes through instead of waiting



PART FOUR · SYNTHESIS

CHAPTER 10

MUGEN SWING

Toward a Syncopic Ontology

> *To be human, in the series' ontology, is to be the pause between two beats.*

10.1 SYNCOPE AND MA
10.2 THE DREAM-PHANTASM PLAY
10.3 THE HOMOLOGY
10.4 THE UBUNE ECONOMY
10.5 HETERODOX RELEASE
10.6 THE ETHICS OF COMPING
10.7 PROPOSITIONS OF A SYNCOPIC ONTOLOGY
10.8 WHY "MUGEN SWING"

10

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS ASSIGNED the figures their temporalities, identified the exits the series refuses, and built the constellation in which it belongs. This chapter assembles them into a single account. Its thesis is that *Cowboy Bebop* is a dream-phantasm play performed in swing time: a work whose dramaturgy is homologous with Zeami's *mugen nō*, whose musical grammar is bebop's, whose economy is the cormorant boat's, whose ending is a heterodox release from repetition, and whose ethics is the ethics of accompaniment. The name proposed for the whole is **Mugen Swing**.

10.1 SYNCOPE AND MA

The concept of syncope, introduced in the Introduction, can now be stated formally in its three registers.

The elided beat. Every principal figure is constituted by something cut from within: Spike's eye and his staged death, Jet's arm and the law he served, Faye's fifty-four years and her memory, Ed's father, the beef in the dish. These are not accidents of backstory but the structural principle of character, as the director's own account of Spike's artificial eye confirms (Chapter 3). Each figure is a word with a sound elided, and the elision is what gives each its particular pronunciation.

The displaced accent. The strong beat of history, the Gate Accident, has already fallen. The characters live on the weak beats after it, in a solar system whose institutions are thin and whose future is furnished with the past (the anachronotope of Chapter 2). Their freedom is the soloist's, not the composer's: they cannot change the changes, only how they phrase over them. This is the freedom of the contrafact (Chapter 1) and of Jeet Kune Do (Chapter 3).

The swoon. The characters repeatedly faint out of their lives: Spike into sleep and into falls, Faye into cryosleep and amnesia, Gren and Vincent into the chemical dreams of war. Catherine Clément's *La Syncope* traced the swoon across music, mysticism, eroticism and death as the moment in which the subject is absent from itself and time is cut. The series' final syncope is the one from which there is no return.

Japanese aesthetics names the common element of the three registers with a single character, 間, read *ma*: the interval, the pause, the space between. *Ma* is the silence that gives music its shape, the empty space that gives architecture its proportion, the timing that gives comedy its laugh. In the martial arts, *maai* is the combative distance within which interception becomes possible, the space Spike's fighting inhabits. Zeami, in *Kakyō* (1424), observed that audiences are often most moved by the moments when the actor does nothing (*senu hima*, the interval of non-doing), sustained by an inner tension that binds the actions on either side. And the same character forms the second half of *ningen* (人間), the human being, which Watsuji read as betweenness (Chapter 4). The coincidence is philosophically exact. The syncopic subject is *ningen* in a double sense: a person, and an interval. To be human, in the series' ontology, is to be the pause between two beats.

Dōgen supplied the Buddhist metaphysics of the cut. In the "Genjōkōan" fascicle of the *Shōbōgenzō* (1233) he observes that firewood becomes ash and does not become firewood again, yet firewood abides in its own dharma-position as firewood, with a before and an after, and is cut off from before and after (*zengo saidan*); in "Uji" (1240) he teaches that being is time, and that each moment holds the whole of time rather than merely flowing past. For Dōgen the cut does not diminish the moment; it completes it. The series' last syncope has this structure. The final gesture is cut off from what preceded it and from anything that could follow, and it is whole.

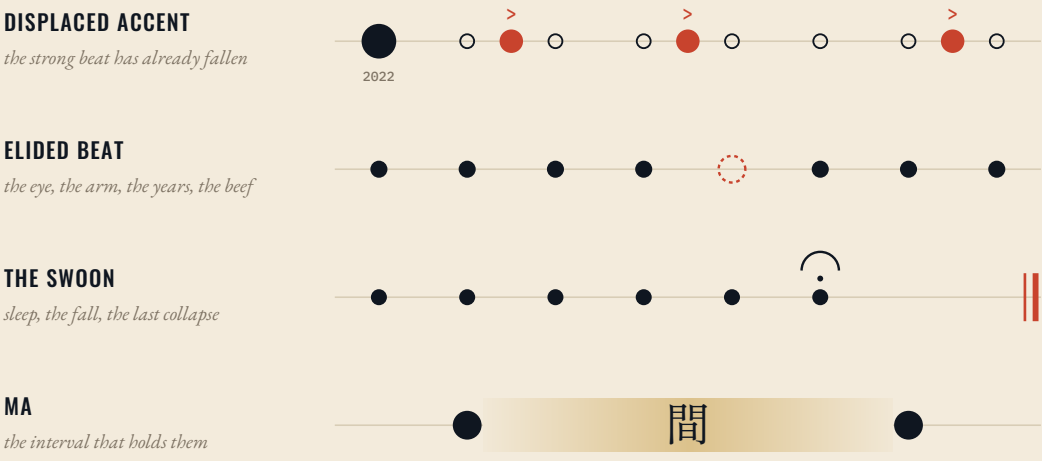


FIG. 8 *Syncope in three registers, and* ma*, the interval that holds them.*

10.2 THE DREAM-PHANTASM PLAY

Zeami Motokiyo (c. 1363–c. 1443), the actor-playwright who gave Noh its classical form and its theory (*Fūshikaden*, c. 1400–1418; *Kakyō*, 1424), perfected a type of play that later scholarship named *mugen nō*, the Noh of dream and phantasm. Its structure is canonical. In the first half (*maeba*), a travelling monk, the secondary actor (*waki*), arrives at a place famous in poetry or history and meets a local person, the principal actor (*shite*), who tells the place's story with a knowledge and grief that hint at a deeper connection, and then vanishes. In the interlude (*ai-kyōgen*), a comic actor playing a villager retells the story to the monk in plain speech. In the second half (*nochiba*), the *shite* returns in true form as the ghost of the person in the story, a fallen warrior or an abandoned woman, re-enacts the moment of attachment or death in dance (*mai*), asks for prayers, and vanishes as dawn breaks; often it is implied that the whole encounter was the monk's dream. In *Atsumori*, the ghost of a young Taira warrior meets the man who killed him, now a monk, and in the end is reconciled with him. In *Izutsu*, the ghost of a woman, wearing her dead husband's robe and cap, gazes into a well and sees his face in her reflection.

The word *mugen* (夢幻) joins the characters for dream and phantasm, and its locus classicus is the closing verse of the *Diamond Sūtra* in Kumārajīva's Chinese translation (402 CE), which teaches that all conditioned things are like a dream, a phantasm, a bubble, a shadow, like dew and like lightning, and should be contemplated as such. The same sound, written 無限, means infinity. A dream-phantasm and an infinity: the double meaning is the series' double condition, a life that is a dream and a repetition that seems endless.

The Noh stage supplies a further correspondence. The *shite* prepares in a room off stage called the *kagami no ma*, the mirror room, where he puts on the mask and contemplates himself in a large mirror until he becomes the character; he then enters along the bridgeway (*hashigakari*) that joins the world of the dead to the stage of the living. The back wall of the stage is the *kagami-ita*, the mirror board, painted with a pine. In a series whose protagonist is named Mirror, the ghost enters through the mirror room.

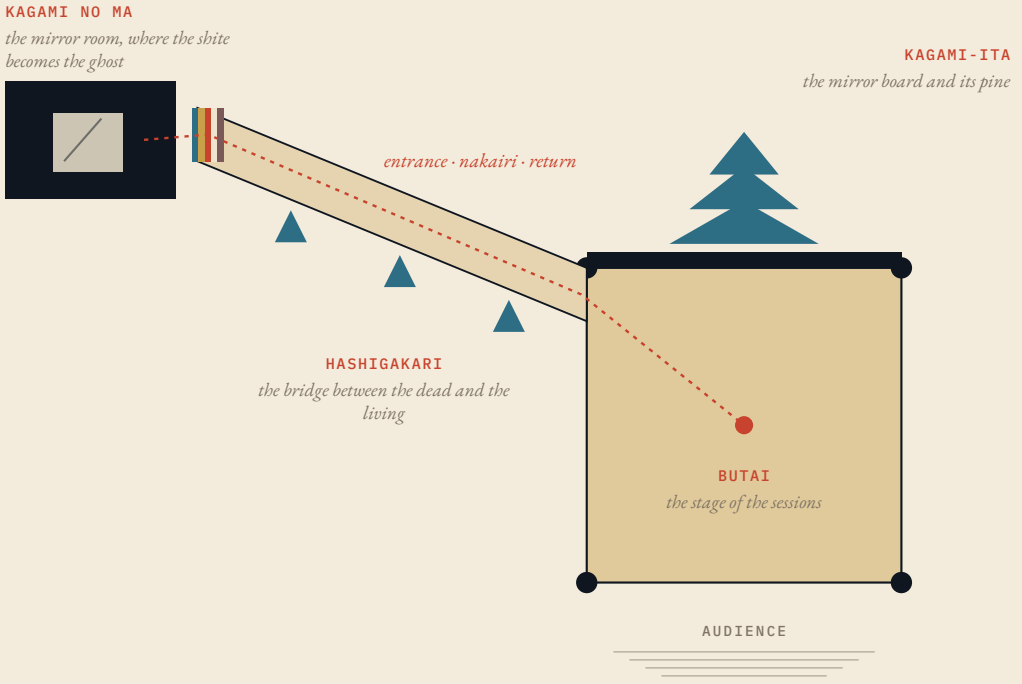


FIG. 9 *Plan of a Noh stage. The* shite *prepares in the mirror room and crosses the bridge between the dead and the living; in a series whose protagonist is named Mirror, the ghost enters through the mirror room.*

10.3 THE HOMOLOGY

The correspondence between Zeami's dramaturgy, bebop's head arrangement and the series' architecture can be set out element by element.

ELEMENT OF MUGEN NŌ	ELEMENT OF THE BEBOP HEAD ARRANGEMENT	REALISATION IN THE SERIES
The *waki* arrives at a famous place	The count-in	The broadcast tagline declares a new genre; in Session 1 a stranger's failed flight with a lover prefigures the end
The *shite* appears in disguise	The head stated obliquely	Spike as idle bounty hunter, Sessions 1–11, his past only glimpsed
First intimation of the ghost's identity	First full statement of the head	Session 5: the cathedral, the fall, Vicious
Nakairi: the *shite* leaves the stage	The break	Sessions 12–13: Spike leaves the Bebop for Callisto at the sound of Julia's name
Ai-kyōgen: the story retold in plain speech	The bridge	Gren tells Faye the history of the war and of Vicious while Spike is gone
Kyōgen farces between plays	Solos and trading fours	The comic sessions: forgotten food, hunger, hallucination, costume cowboys
Nochiba: the ghost returns in true form	The head restated	Sessions 25–26: Spike returns to the Red Dragon as what he was
Mai: the dance re-enacting attachment	The final chorus	The last fight, choreographed as dance
The ghost vanishes at dawn	The tag ending and the cut	The descent into the rising sun, the mimed shot, the collapse, the fading star, the closing card
Jo-ha-kyū (introduction, development, rush)	Tempo across the set	Episodic leisure, deepening middle, the compressed final three sessions

Three features of the homology deserve emphasis. First, the *kyōgen*. Classical Noh programmes alternate the ghost plays with *kyōgen* farces, many of which concern hunger and the frustrated desire to eat and drink. In *Bō shibari*, two servants tied to poles to stop them stealing sake contrive to drink it anyway; in *Busu*, servants told that a jar contains poison discover it is sugar and devour it. The series' comic sessions are *kyōgen* in exactly this sense: earthy, food-obsessed farces placed between the ghost-play movements, their humour the obverse of the same hunger that drives the tragedy. By the staff's own account they were harder to write than the serious episodes, their apparent randomness planned in advance; they are not digressions from the series' seriousness but its necessary alternation, as *kyōgen* is necessary to a day of Noh.

Second, the *ai-kyōgen*. Gren's function in Sessions 12 and 13 is formally that of the interlude narrator: while the *shite* is off stage pursuing his past, a figure from the margins tells the story plainly to a witness (Faye) who did not know it. That Gren stands between the living and the dead, and between the war and the present, suits the role; that his body was altered by drug trials forced on him in prison is a harm the series records, not a symbol for the reader to admire (see Chapter 7). The *ai-kyōgen* is the one actor who speaks in ordinary language, and Gren is the one character who speaks of the past without metaphor.

Third, the *waki*. The witness in Noh is usually a monk whose prayers can release the ghost. The series' witnesses are Jet and Faye (and, beyond them, the audience). They cannot pray Spike free, and he does not ask them to. The series thus preserves the structure of *mugen nō* while re-

moving its soteriology: the ghost re-enacts its attachment before witnesses who can only watch. The question of release passes from the witness to the ghost himself.

10.4 THE UBUNE ECONOMY

Chapter 7 read Vicious's cormorant through *ukai*. The emblem can now be extended to the whole system. The Bebop was built as a fishing boat to work the seas of Ganymede. It carries a fighter named for a swordfish and a tug named for a hammerhead shark. Its captain wields a net-gun and its youngest member works the net. Its quarry is called a head. Its crew catches what it cannot swallow: bounties escape, die, are claimed by others, or cost more in damages than they pay. The series opens on a meal named for the meat it lacks. The Bebop is an *ubune*, a cormorant boat, and its crew are the ringed birds.

The **ubune economy** may be defined as an economy in which the hunter's labour is appropriated at the throat, the point of consumption, so that the hunter is suspended between catching and swallowing. It is the material form of the syncopic condition. The elided beat in the body (the missing eye, arm, years) has its counterpart in the elided meal; the displaced accent of history has its counterpart in the deferred payment; the swoon has its counterpart in hunger's faintness. Nietzsche's identity of guilt and debt (Chapter 2), Graeber's anthropology of debt, and Lazzarato's indebted subject describe the economy's logic; Tantalus and the ringed cormorant give it its Greek and Japanese faces; Bashō's haiku gives it its affect, delight turning to sorrow.

The economy also clarifies the ending. There are two ways to break a cormorant's ring. Vicious's way is to kill the master, and it fails, because the ring is not held by the master but by the bird's own nature as a hunter of what belongs to others. Spike's way is the other: to stop hunting and become the quarry. In the final session he walks into the syndicate as the head on which the past has set a price, and delivers it. His mimed shot on the staircase is the one bounty in the series that is finally collected: his own. The hunter brings in his head.

10.5 HETERODOX RELEASE

The cat that lived a million times (Chapter 9) gives the series its theory of release, and the theory is heterodox in a precise sense. In Buddhist doctrine the suffering of conditioned existence (*duḥkha*) arises from craving (*tṛṣṇā*); attachment binds beings to the round of rebirth (*saṃsāra*); liberation (*nirvāṇa*) is the extinction of craving. Sano's fable keeps the structure (a cycle of rebirths, a final release from it) and inverts its mechanism. The cat is reborn endlessly because he is unattached; he is released because he loves and grieves.

Spike's trajectory follows the fable. His million lives are the sessions: bounty after bounty, fall after fall, each met with the indifference of a cat who does not cry. His white cat is Julia. Her death is the grief that completes his attachment, and his death follows without return. The series supplies no resurrection: its film is set within the run, before the end, and the ending is not revis-

ited. The *mugen nō* ghost is released by the monk's prayers; the cat is released by his own grief; Spike is released by his own act, which is grief performed as a walk.

The release can be specified against three philosophical alternatives. Against Nietzsche's eternal recurrence (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*, §341), which asks whether one could will one's life again innumerable times, Spike neither affirms recurrence nor denies it; he completes it. Against the alternatives Kuki Shūzō set out in his Pontigny lectures of 1928, which contrasted the Buddhist will to be delivered from recurrence with a will, schooled in the warrior ethic, that would go on facing the endless round with pride, Spike chooses neither deliverance by insight nor endurance without end, but a third term Kuki did not name: deliverance by completion. Against the Zen injunction to die the great death once (*daishi ichiban*), meaning the death of the ego in awakening, Spike dies a literal death that is also, in the series' metaphor, an awakening from the dream. Nishitani Keiji argued in *Shūkyō to wa nanika* (1961; *Religion and Nothingness*, 1982) that nihilism can be overcome only by passing through it to the standpoint of emptiness (*kū*), where things are affirmed in their suchness. Vicious remains in what Nishitani called relative nothingness, the void that negates; Spike's last gesture, a joke, a finger pointed like a gun, a single word, is an affirmation from the other side.

Nishitani's standpoint has its own political history. In 1941 and 1942 he took part, with Kōsaka Masaaki, Kōyama Iwao and Suzuki Shigetaka, in the *Chūō kōron* roundtables later published as *Sekaishiteki tachiba to Nihon* (*The World-Historical Standpoint and Japan*, 1943), which presented Japan's war as a world-historical mission, and in the 1942 symposium on "Overcoming Modernity"; after the war he was purged from his university post under the Occupation and reinstated in 1952. The overcoming of nihilism his later work describes was, in its wartime form, lent to the justification of an empire's war. This study takes from him the distinction between a nothingness that negates and an emptiness that affirms, and uses it, as it uses Heidegger, against the politics to which its author once attached it.

This study calls the result a **heterodox release**: liberation from repetition achieved not by renouncing attachment but by carrying it to completion. It is heterodox to Buddhism, which seeks release through non-attachment; to Christian eschatology, which defers release to a judgement; to existentialism, which refuses release altogether; and to the romantic *Liebestod*, which seeks union in death. Spike seeks no union. He seeks to know whether he is alive, and the series answers, in the last frame, that he was.

10.6 THE ETHICS OF COMPING

In jazz, to comp (from accompany, and complement) is the practice of the rhythm section, above all the pianist or guitarist, who supports the soloist with chords and rhythmic punctuation: listening, responding, filling the gaps, leaving space, never taking over the line. Comping is an ethics in miniature. It requires attention to another's phrasing, a sense of when to play and when not to, and a willingness to be heard only as support.

The crew of the Bebop comp for one another. They rarely say they care and frequently say they do not. They show up: Jet nursing Spike after the cathedral, Spike crossing the solar system to rescue Faye, Faye returning to a ship she has repeatedly robbed, Ed hacking for people who forget to thank her, Ein watching. Their community is not a family (no kinship), a contract (no payment), a fraternity (no oath) or a congregation (no faith). It is an ensemble: a set of soloists who accompany each other for the duration of a set and are free to leave when it ends.

Comping ethics refines the instruments of earlier chapters. With Watsuji it shares the primacy of betweenness, but it is lighter than *aidagara*: it binds through practice, not position. With the ethics of care it shares attentiveness and responsiveness, but it adds a sense of timing and of space: the virtue of leaving room, of not playing over another's line. Jet's failure with Alisa was a failure to comp; he played over her. With Levinas's ethics of the face (*Totalité et infini*, 1961) it shares asymmetry (the accompanist serves the soloist), but it is reciprocal across the set (everyone solos; everyone comps). Its defining virtue is the one *ma* names: respect for the interval. The ensemble survives the departure of its members because comping is not possession. Faye's return to the Bebop (Chapter 5) is the ethic made visible as a home.

10.7 PROPOSITIONS OF A SYNCOPIC ONTOLOGY

The argument can be condensed into eight propositions.

1. The subject is constituted by an elided beat: a lack, wound or loss cut from within it, which shapes its whole pronunciation.
2. History's downbeat has already fallen; existence is phrasing on the weak beats that follow a catastrophe one did not witness.
3. Freedom is timing within inherited changes (the contrafact), not sovereignty over them.
4. The economy of the hunt suspends the subject between catching and swallowing (the ubune economy), so that hunger and debt are the material form of metaphysical suspension.
5. Every exit that abolishes the interval (sovereignty, upload, apocalypse, arrest, regression) is a death disguised as liberation.
6. The interval can be inhabited ethically by accompaniment (comping) and aesthetically by style (*iki*).
7. Release is not escape from repetition but the completion of a phrase in an act of consummated attachment (heterodox release).
8. The work of art (the session) is the place where this ontology becomes perceptible, because only in music and its analogues can a weak beat be heard as the place where meaning lives.

10.8 WHY "MUGEN SWING"

Swing is the felt quality of jazz rhythm: the uneven subdivision of the beat, the slight lag and push against the metre, the sense that time is alive because it is not exactly kept. Duke Ellington's 1931 title, "It Don't Mean a Thing (If It Ain't Got That Swing)," made the quality into a criterion of meaning. *Mugen* is the dream-phantasm of the Noh and, by homophony, infinity. **Mugen Swing** names the series' achievement: a dream-phantasm play performed in swing time, in which a ghost re-enacts its attachment before witnesses who cannot save it, over a groove that seems endless and is not. The swing is what makes the dream bearable; the dream is what makes the swing grieve. Together they constitute a philosophy of the interval, in which the human being, *ningen*, is the pause between beats, and in which the measure of a life is not how long it lasts but how it is phrased.

CONCLUSION · CODA

BANG, OR CARRYING THE WEIGHT

> *What the audience carries is not a moral but a rhythm.*

C.1 THE LAST GESTURE
C.2 THE WEIGHT
C.3 CONTRIBUTIONS
C.4 FURTHER RESEARCH
C.5 CODA

CODA

C.1 THE LAST GESTURE

THE SERIES ENDS ON a gesture so economical that it has become an emblem of the medium. Mortally wounded, Spike descends the staircase of the syndicate's headquarters, into the light of the rising sun, towards the soldiers gathered at its foot. He raises his hand, fingers shaped into a pistol, says a single word (*bang*), smiles, and falls. The image rises to a star, which fades. A closing card follows.

Every strand of this dissertation passes through the gesture. It is the child's gesture of play, the finger-gun of the playground, so that the ludic principle Ed carried out of the ship (Chapter 6) returns at the moment of death. It is a shot that kills no one, the cormorant's ring removed at last: the hunter makes the hunter's sign and brings in no head but his own (Chapter 10). It is a single accented syllable followed by silence, the syncope in all three of its registers at once: the elided beat (the bullet that is not there), the displaced accent (a word spoken after the fight has ended, on the weak beat of the action), and the swoon. Jean-Luc Nancy's *Le Discours de la syncope* (1976) read syncope as the cut that discourse cannot master within itself; here discourse ends in an onomatopoeia, language reduced to the sound it once imitated. It is the *Augenblick*, the eye-glance in which, for once, both of Spike's eyes see the same time (Chapter 3). And it is, quite literally, the vanishing of the ghost at dawn, the end of the *mugen nō*, in which the witnesses are left with an empty stage and a story they must now carry (Chapter 10).

Freud's account of his grandson's game in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (Chapter 3) adds a last gloss. The child mastered absence by throwing a reel out of sight with a cry heard as *fort*, gone, and reeling it back with *da*, there. Spike's finger-gun is a child's game of making-disappear played once, without the return: *fort* without *da*. A series that repeated its losses for twenty-six sessions ends on one it does not reel back.

Whether Spike dies is a question the series answers by every formal means and refuses to answer by statement. The star fades; there is no further session; the film is set before the end. The refusal of statement is not coyness but consistency. A series that has made the interval its ontology ends in an interval, a rest whose duration it does not specify.

The refusal was also deliberate. Watanabe has said that he settled the ending early and kept it, against staff who feared it would foreclose a continuation, partly because he did not want to be bound for years to an endless franchise on the model of *Star Trek*; he later added that stopping while audiences still wanted more was in keeping with the Bebop spirit. The cut was a decision about seriality as much as about a character, and it completes the answer to Adorno given in Chapter 1: a syncope the industry could not reabsorb, because the work itself declined to continue.

C.2 THE WEIGHT

The closing card borrows the title of "Carry That Weight," from the medley that closes the Beatles' *Abbey Road* (1969), the last album the band recorded, which ends with a track called "The End." The citation completes the series' musical self-understanding: the band breaks up, and the last thing it does is hand on a burden.

The burden has a philosophical name. Section 341 of Nietzsche's *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*, the aphorism that first states the thought of eternal recurrence, is titled *Das größte Schwergewicht*, "the greatest weight." Nietzsche imagined a demon proposing that one's life must be lived again innumerable times, and asked whether one would curse the demon or bless him; the thought, he said, would lie on every action as the heaviest weight. Milan Kundera opened *Nesnesitelná lehkost bytí* (*The Unbearable Lightness of Being*, 1984) by asking whether weight or lightness is the positive pole of existence, and suggested that a life lived only once weighs nothing. Spike lived lightly, with *iki*, as a man for whom nothing weighed because he had already died. The series ends by restoring weight, and by transferring it. The card is addressed not to the characters but to the audience, who become, in the terms of Chapter 10, the *waki*: the witnesses who must carry the ghost's story away from the stage.

What the audience carries is not a moral but a rhythm. It is the knowledge that a life can be lived on the weak beat, that hunger and debt need not be the last word on a hunter, that the dream from which one cannot wake can still be played well, and that companionship can be real without being permanent. It is, in short, the syncopic ontology itself, handed on in the only form in which it can be transmitted: as a felt time.

C.3 CONTRIBUTIONS

This dissertation has made five contributions. First, it has shown that the series' eclectic surface is organised by the bebop contrafact, and has proposed the term *blue parody* for citation coloured by loss, against Jameson's blank parody and Azuma's database. Second, it has named the series' temporal setting an *anachronotope*, a future furnished with the past, and read it as an anticipation of the hauntological diagnosis of the following decade. Third, it has read the principal figures as distinct temporalities (revenant, maintaining, anachronic, ludic), and shown that the Japanese philosophical tradition (Kuki, Watsuji, Zeami, Nishitani) supplies instruments more precise than the existentialist vocabulary that has dominated discussion. Fourth, it has proposed the structural homology between the series and Zeami's *mugen nō*, mediated by the bebop head arrangement, under the name *Mugen Swing*. Fifth, it has articulated a syncopic ontology with three subsidiary concepts, the ubune economy, heterodox release and the ethics of comping, which together offer a philosophical account of existence after catastrophe that neither the existentialist nor the Buddhist tradition supplies on its own.

C.4 FURTHER RESEARCH

Several lines of inquiry open from here. A musicological study of Kanno's score, building on Rose Bridges's monograph and attentive to harmonic language and to the placement of music against image, would test the claim that the score functions as narrator. A reception history of the series' English-language broadcast from 2001, when it became for many viewers the first anime they took seriously, would illuminate how a work built on transnational citation was itself received as a citation of Japan. A comparative study of Watanabe's later work (*Samurai Champloo*, *Sakamichi no Apollon*, *Zankyou no terror*, *Carole & Tuesday* and *Lazarus*) would test whether the contrafact method persists as historiography. A study of the late Keiko Nobumoto's writing as a body of work, from *Macross Plus* through *Wolf's Rain* and *Tokyo Godfathers*, would recover a screenwriter whose preoccupations (the impossible home, the found family, the end of a world) this dissertation has attributed in part to the series' formal intelligence and which belong also, demonstrably, to her. And the 2021 live-action adaptation, released by Netflix in November 2021 to mixed-to-negative reviews and cancelled the following month after a single season, offers a test of this study's central claim. If the series' meaning is carried by its rhythm (the alternation of farce and requiem, the ending kept against the logic of the franchise, the cut), then a transposition that preserves characters, costumes and score while changing pacing and serial design should lose more than its surface. Reviews alone cannot settle whether the adaptation's reception confirms the hypothesis; that requires a study of the adaptation itself.

C.5 CODA

The series called its episodes sessions, and a session is defined by the fact that it ends. Musicians gather, play the head, take their choruses, return to the head and pack up their instruments; the room empties; what remains is the memory of a time that was shaped. *Cowboy Bebop* is twenty-six sessions and a film about people who could not change the key in which history had been written and who chose, within it, how to phrase. Its last word is a syllable and its last image is a star going out. Between them lies the interval this dissertation has tried to describe: the place where, in the series' ontology, the human being lives, on the weak beat, carrying the weight.

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INDEX TERMS

KEYWORDS

COWBOY BEBOP · SHINICHIRŌ WATANABE · KEIKO NOBUMOTO · YOKO KANNO · ANIME STUDIES · ANIMATION AND PHILOSOPHY · SYNCOPE · SYNCOPIC ONTOLOGY · MA (INTERVAL) · SENU HIMA · MUGEN NŌ · ZEAMI MOTOKIYO · KYŌGEN · JO-HA-KYŪ · BEBOP · CONTRAFACT · HEAD ARRANGEMENT · BLUES · SIGNIFYIN(G) · BLUE PARODY · ANACHRONOTOPE · HAUNTOLOGY · LOST FUTURES · SPACE WESTERN · FRONTIER THESIS · PROFESSIONAL PLOT · BOUNTY AND DEBT · UBUNE ECONOMY · UKAI · BASHŌ · HETERODOX RELEASE · THE CAT THAT LIVED A MILLION TIMES · ETHICS OF COMPING · CARE ETHICS · AIDAGARA · FŪDO · WATSUJI TETSURŌ · KUKI SHŪZŌ · IKI · NISHITANI KEIJI · KIERKEGAARD · THE MOMENT (ØIEBLIK, AUGENBLICK) · REPETITION · HEIDEGGER · BEING-TOWARDS-DEATH · CAMUS · THE ABSURD · SARTRE · BAD FAITH · BRUCE LEE · JEET KUNE DO · HAGAKURE · REVENANT · MIRROR STAGE · GIRARD · MIMETIC RIVALRY · GIRI AND NINJŌ · CHIKAMATSU MONZAEMON · NINKYŌ EIGA · URASHIMA TARŌ · ORPHEUS · IZANAGI AND IZANAMI · FLYING DUTCHMAN · TANTALUS · ZHUANGZI · BUTTERFLY DREAM · MUKOKUSEKI · DIASPORA · POST-BUBBLE JAPAN · AUM SHINRIKYŌ · POSTHUMANISM · MIND UPLOADING · MEDIA ARCHAEOLOGY · BETAMAX · LA JETÉE · SOLARIS · NEUROMANCER · NIETZSCHE · ETERNAL RECURRENCE · THE GREATEST WEIGHT · FREUD · MELANCHOLIA · REPETITION COMPULSION · FORT–DA · WALTER BENJAMIN · ANGEL OF HISTORY · DŌGEN · BEING-TIME · HEIKE MONOGATARI · RALPH ELLISON · APPROPRIATION AND AUTHENTICITY · KYOTO SCHOOL · POLITICAL HISTORY OF PHILOSOPHY · MISHIMA YUKIO · RED EYE

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